

THE RADIUS SPECTRUM OF GAMES, AND SIMULTANEOUS *Go* VIA OBJECTIVE QUANTUM REDUCTION

YASHA SAVELYEV

ABSTRACT. Based on the theory of simultaneization developed here, we introduce an isomorphism invariant of combinatorial games valued in subsets of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$, called the radius spectrum. It is an invariant of the dynamics, orthogonal to quantitative data such as cardinality, and to the scoring. We then draw a stark line between chess and *Go*: the radius spectrum of *Go* is all of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$, of chess $\{0\}$. The proof factors through the construction of a particular simple symmetric simultaneization *SGo* of *Go*, all terms being mathematical notions. *SGo* is striking purely as a game: it is refereed by the display alone, and it is sharper and unreasonably deeper (three times in our particular test) than *Go* in computer simulations. Its rules are simple, especially mathematically; in fact the Komi, Ko and suicide rules of *Go* are removed. For these reasons we take time to describe it gently and fully. The main results and the game engine have been formalized and machine verified in Lean, but human readable proofs are provided here. The construction of *SGo* is inspired by physical quantum theory, despite the game being combinatorial.

1. INTRODUCTION

At a basic level we study simultaneizations of combinatorial games and use this to derive qualitative invariants of their game dynamics. There are intrinsic reasons why one may want to simultaneize a game – in particular *Go*. The latter is an ancient game governed by local-to-global geometric principles. It is a sequential game (that is, turns alternate between the two players), which has the benefit of a very simple theoretical structure, (mostly) fitting into the subject of combinatorial game theory. But for *Go* this structure creates asymmetries which force departures from local-to-global principles – mainly Ko fights.¹ One idea is that with simultaneization we can remove the Ko rule completely, and of course Komi.

The basic finding is that perhaps due to its local-to-global nature, *Go* is almost simultaneous. We make this precise by proving that *Go*, on a board of side at least five, has simple symmetric simultaneizations of faithfulness radius any $k \in \mathbb{N}$ or ∞ , see Theorem 5.2. Much of the general theory of simultaneizations is developed in the present paper.

The faithfulness radius calculations lead us to introduce an isomorphism invariant of the dynamics of a game G , orthogonal to quantitative data such as cardinality, and to the scoring – the radius spectrum of G , valued in subsets of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$. For *Go* it is $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$, by Theorem 5.2; in contrast, for chess it is $\{0\}$, by Theorem 5.6. The main results, the game engines, and simultaneization theory have been formalized in Lean <https://yashamon.github.io/web2/papers/>

¹If a player engages in a Ko fight, they must make moves that are strategically disconnected.

[sgoleanformalization/](#), in particular Theorem 5.2 and the supporting Lemma 5.3.

The proof of Theorem 5.2 factors through the construction of the radius zero game *SGo*, and it is the star here – it is an easy to play game with razor sharp and deep dynamics. It is a combinatorial symmetric simultaneous game, which is played on a standard *Go* board and refereed by the display alone², although we need a third type of stone that we call q-stones, represented by colored stones. It is in some ways a simpler game than *Go* as it loses the Komi, Ko and suicide rules, and it has just two rules: stone placement and capture (aside from the end of game rule). Like classical *Go*, *SGo* has very robust game dynamics. We make this precise via some empirical studies outlined in Section 2.1 and Section 6.2. In computer simulations random games of *SGo* appear to be sharper than those of *Go*, markedly so at 19×19 (but this must be properly interpreted). More interestingly, *SGo* is a much deeper game than *Go* on 5×5 , with an Elo ladder three times the height. These statistics are preliminary; the methodology is coarse and the sample sizes moderate. But *SGo* being deeper should be unsurprising from the construction alone, as the state space is much larger and the evolution rule more intricate.

The idea for *SGo* is loosely inspired by quantum mechanics. The rough idea is to branch the game state whenever the moves of the two players do not commute or otherwise interfere in classical *Go*. This is part of a more general theory of universal simultaneization of certain sequential games developed in Section 4.4, and this may be of independent interest. However, the universal simultaneization generally has uninteresting dynamics; in the case of *Go* this is seen empirically, cf. Section 2.1. To get interesting dynamics, the *SGo* game evolution (capture rule) invokes “objective reduction of the quantum state” – it is a deterministic, generally easy, objective operation performed on the board. The term objective reduction was coined by Penrose, see for instance [21]; in terms of the branch semantics we are collapsing certain branches.

Of course, the word quantum is used figuratively: there is no unitary time evolution, no complex amplitudes, and no probabilistic outcomes. The game is combinatorial and deterministic, and it would not be appropriate to call it “quantum Go”. For games with genuine quantum features see for instance [7], and for a quantum version of *Go* itself [24].

Using the Nash equilibrium theorem [19], we show that *SGo* has a mixed equilibrium strategy to draw on average. That said, finding this even approximately is likely only practical on very small boards, due to the unreal size of the strategy space. We can also ask if *SGo* has a strategy to draw, not just to draw on average; on the 2×2 board both players do, but already on the 3×3 board neither player has one, so optimal play is necessarily mixed (Section 4.2).

The classical game *Go* has inspired a wealth of research on combinatorial game theory, see for instance [2], [26]. It also led to Conway’s theory of surreal numbers [4]. There is also research on simultaneous and synchronized combinatorial games, see for instance [3], [11], [12]. We expect that *SGo* will provide a simple but rich example that can help with further study of such games.

²Note that this is beyond even chess and *Go*: the latter have, for instance, castling rights and Ko rules that are not purely display driven.

2. GAME RULES OF *SGo*

The game *SGo* is initialized with an empty standard *Go* board, with horizontal/vertical lines whose intersections we just call intersections. There are two players that we call Black and White. As in *Go*, players Black and White move on a given turn by placing a black respectively white stone on an empty intersection on the board, but in *SGo* they do this on the same turn without knowledge of the other’s move on this turn. We allow pass moves as in *Go*. The board the players see and play on we call the **display**. Every stone of the display carries a **time stamp** – the turn of its placement – as part of the display’s data. The capture conditions below read the stamps. Simultaneous action requires modifying the placement and capture rules of *Go*, while removing the Komi, Ko, and suicide rules. We also need to introduce a third type of stone, called **q-stones** (quantum stones), which may be thought of as simultaneously white and black. On the board a q-stone is displayed *red* or, as a visual aid, *blue* when a capture is currently blocked through it, in the sense of the capture conditions below; the colors red and blue are purely visual and carry no rule content.

2.1. Motivation for the rules. Before we proceed to the main rules, we briefly overview the motivation and constraints we impose. We require:

- (1) *SGo* forms a simple simultaneization of *Go*, in the precise sense of Theorem 5.2. Being a simultaneization means that *SGo* naturally maps to the universal simultaneization of *Go*.
- (2) It is played on a standard *Go* board and refereed purely by the display. This in particular requires us to represent simultaneous moves to the same intersection, and we choose to do this by introducing q-stones (visually red or blue).
- (3) No Ko or other non repetition rules.
- (4) We want *SGo* to have comparable game dynamics to the standard *Go*. This is far from the case for the universal simultaneization $\text{Sim}(Go)$ of *Go*, as considered in Section 4.4. For $\text{Sim}(Go)$, games tend to be drawn due to players lacking forcing options.

To achieve these dynamics, we utilize an “objective reduction” process acting on the display each turn (Section 2.5). This is entirely display driven and elementary. In the language of the universal simultaneization, it prunes certain branched histories resulting from simultaneous action, using objective global board information. This has the effect of giving players very forcing options, see Section 3.2 for some examples. But this is not without constraints: we need the game to stay symmetric, while having a well defined deterministic state evolution, as elaborated by Lemma 2.4. We also cannot prune too much, for example in the suicidal capture condition in Definition 2.2 we intentionally preserve certain branching to avoid the Ko type infinite loops, also see Remark 2.3.

Requirement (4) is supported by computer experiments.³ The main comparison plays both games on their common rule base – the variant of *Go* fixed before

³The simulations and exact computations reported in this paper, together with extensive machine verification of its rules, examples, and arguments – including an exhaustive census of the one-turn faithfulness conditions over every legal classical state of the 3×3 board – were carried out by Claude, an AI system by Anthropic.

Theorem 5.2 (suicide legal, no superko rule) – under uniformly random play over all legal board moves, passing only when none is available; 1000 games per variant (200 in the last column). On the 5×5 board the game bound of Section 4.2 is set to 40 turns; on 19×19 , *SGo* is left unbounded, while *Go* is stopped at 1500 turns:

	<i>SGo</i> 5×5	<i>Go</i> 5×5	<i>SGo</i> 19×19	<i>Go</i> 19×19
mean margin	13.6	12.0	235.3	68.8
draws	4.6%	5.4%	0.0%	4.5%
games ending on their own	99%	0%	100%	50%
mean length in turns	22.4	39.9	398	1106
q-stones created per game	3.3	–	8.6	–
q-stones on the final display	2.3	–	5.0	–
peak recursion depth	1.1	–	1.0	–

Here the mean margin is the absolute difference of the two area counts, and a game ends on its own when the end of the game rule fires before the bound or cap (the 19×19 figures for *Go* are censored at the cap, so its true mean length is larger still). On 5×5 the margins are nearly identical and the draw rates similar, and the difference is termination: 99% of *SGo* games ended of their own accord within the bound – and with the bound lifted, every one of them does, in 22.4 turns on average – while every classical game was still churning when the bound stopped it. On 19×19 the difference is dramatic on both counts: random *SGo* ends by itself on a decisively settled board, with mean margin exceeding half the board, while half of the classical games were still cycling, far from settled, when stopped (every one of the thousand *SGo* games ended on its own).

Disabling the objective reduction – approximating the dynamics of the universal simultaneization of Section 4.4 – collapses the game completely: no stone is then ever removed, the two colors necessarily place equal numbers of stones, and all 500 simulated 5×5 games ended in exact draws. The objective reduction is the entire engine of the dynamics.

One may wonder how informed play changes the above distributions; and also what the depth estimates look like; we partially address this in Sections 6.1 and 6.3.

Finally, the last three rows of the table concern the quantum layer. A finished *SGo* game displays on average about two q-stones on the small board, and five among the 361 points of the large one, so the display stays nearly classical. The recursion depth of a turn is the number of basic capture reductions (Section 2.5) in its resolution that remove a stone. Its peak over a game averages barely above one, and it never exceeded three in the thousand games at either size. In other words, nearly every turn resolves analogously to *Go*, despite the “quantum engine”.

2.2. Some definitions. Given a board state s , that is any (at the moment no legality restrictions) collection of white, black, and q-stones on the board, each stone implicitly time stamped, let $G(s)$ denote the graph with vertices stones, and an edge between vertices whenever the corresponding stones are horizontally or vertically adjacent. (Meaning they are adjacent and on the same horizontal/vertical line.) The display is a board state. From now on adjacency always means this type of adjacency. In what follows the terms stones and vertices may be used synonymously.

A **unicolor component** C is a connected component of the full (a.k.a. induced) subgraph of $G(s)$ whose vertices are either all the black, or all the white stones. (Full subgraph means that all the edges of the original graph, between any pair of

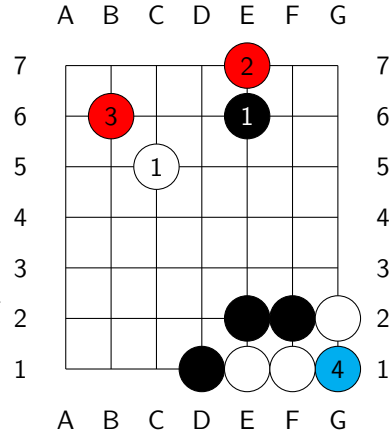
vertices of the subgraph, are included.) In this case we call C **black**, respectively **white**. We may less often refer to **q-components**, analogously defined as connected components of q-stones.

As in classical *Go*, a connected component C **has no liberties** if it is not adjacent to an empty intersection (this is short for C does not contain a stone adjacent to an empty intersection). We will also call C a **trapped component**.

We define stones **adjacent** to C as those stones (not in C) whose corresponding vertices are connected by an edge to C in $G(s)$.

2.3. Stone placement rule of SGo. If the players move to the same intersection i on the board, a q-stone is placed at i .

To the right is an example of the placement rule. On turn one the players move to different intersections and both stones are placed as in classical *Go*. On turns two, three and four they move to the same intersection – E7, B6 and G1 respectively – and each conflict yields a q-stone. (One can check that no capture then occurs on turn 4: the blue stone blocks both parts of condition 3 for the white component E1, F1.)



2.4. Capture rule of SGo. After both White and Black move on the current turn numbered n , using the stone placement rule above we get a display D .

Definition 2.1. We say that a black, white, or q-component C is **trapped on turn n** if C is trapped and n is the largest stamp among the stones of C and the stones adjacent to C . A stone is called **trapped** on turn n , if it is an element of C as above. We say that a q-stone is **trapped by white respectively black on turn n** (white, respectively black, being the capturing side), if replacing it by a black respectively white stone it is trapped on turn n . For a black respectively white stone, trapped by white respectively black on turn n will simply mean trapped on turn n .

Definition 2.2. A white component C is resolved as **captured on this turn** if the following is satisfied:

- (1) C is trapped on this turn.
- (2) If C is adjacent to a q-stone that is itself adjacent to another trapped component, then that component is white. (Without this condition Lemma 2.4 does not work, and the game evolution will be ill defined.)
- (3) One of the following holds:
 - (a) No black stone or q-stone adjacent to C is trapped by white on this turn.
 - (b) (Suicidal capture) No stone in C is created on this turn. If C is adjacent to a stone trapped on this turn, then the component of that

stone contains a stone that is created on this turn and is not a q-stone.

Remark 2.3. *The suicidal capture property may appear complicated, but is driven by our requirements, as outlined in Section 2.1. For example, if we remove the part of the condition “is not a q-stone”, then Ko type infinite loops will become possible later. If we remove the condition “no stone in C is created on this turn”, then the proof of Theorem 5.2 will fail.*

In the case C is captured:

- The stones of C are removed as in *Go*.
- Any q-stones adjacent to C resolve as black. (Concretely, they are replaced by black stones.)

A stone converted this way is not considered to be placed or created on this turn; it retains the placement turn of the q-stone it replaces.

If C is a black component the process is naturally mirrored. As far as the rules are concerned this process is simultaneous for all captured components, cf. Lemma 2.4.

2.5. Capture reduction. We call the above the *basic capture reduction* of D , denoted $\widetilde{Cap}_n(D)$. The *capture reduction* is

$$Cap_n(D) = \lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} \widetilde{Cap}_n^k(D).$$

The sequence is eventually constant, an application removing a stone or fixing the display. In practice the limit is attained at $k = 1$, as is the case in the examples of Section 3 below.

Lemma 2.4. *The basic capture reduction is well defined. Namely, no q-stone is adjacent to components of both colors captured on this turn, so that the displayed conversion of q-stones is unambiguous.*

Proof. Suppose that a q-stone r is adjacent to unicolor components C_0, C_1 , both captured on this turn, with C_0 white and C_1 black. As C_1 is captured, it is in particular trapped. So C_0 is adjacent to the q-stone r , which is itself adjacent to the trapped component C_1 of the opposite color, and Condition 2 fails for C_0 . This contradicts the assumption that C_0 is captured.

Thus, each q-stone adjacent to some component captured on this turn is adjacent to captured components of only one color, and so its conversion is unambiguous. As the removal of stones is likewise unambiguous, each simultaneous resolution step, and hence the basic capture reduction, is well defined. $\square$

If the capture reduction removes no stones, the turn is resolved. Otherwise, define $R^k(D)$ by:

$$\begin{aligned} R^1(D) &= Cap_n(D). \\ R^k(D) &= Cap_{n-k+1}(R^{k-1}(D)). \end{aligned}$$

That is, at stage k the capture conditions of Definition 2.2 are applied with “this turn” read as turn $n - k + 1$. The recursion stops as soon as $R^k(D) = R^{k-1}(D)$, and the turn is then resolved. The total effect is the *objective reduction* (or just OR) of the turn:

$$OR(D) = R^k(D).$$

Remark 2.5. *In practice the resolution of most turns is easy to work out mentally. This is actually quantifiable; in the statistics of Section 2.1 the peak recursion depth never exceeded three and was typically one.*

2.6. End of the game. An *SGo* game ends if one of the following holds:

- The players agree to end the game, in this case they may also agree to remove some black/white stones from the board as dead. (As is common in standard play of *Go*.) This is the main way of ending the game.
- The display is unchanged after each of two consecutive turns. For example, both players perform a single stone suicide on the same turn twice in a row, or pass twice in a row.
- The display has no empty intersections.

We then decide the winner using Chinese *Go*-style rules. So the winner is decided by comparing the two area counts, which we now explain.

We say that an empty intersection i on the board **reaches black respectively white** if there is a connected component of empty intersections (as usual meaning a connected component of the graph with vertices empty intersections on the board and edges adjacencies) that contains i and contains an intersection adjacent to a black stone respectively white stone.

We say i is **surrounded by black** if:

- i reaches black.
- i does not reach white. (To emphasize it could reach a q-stone.)

We define surrounded by white analogously. Then in the case of player Black the area count is the sum of:

- (1) The number of black stones on the board.
- (2) The number of empty intersections surrounded by black.

See Section 3.6 for an example.

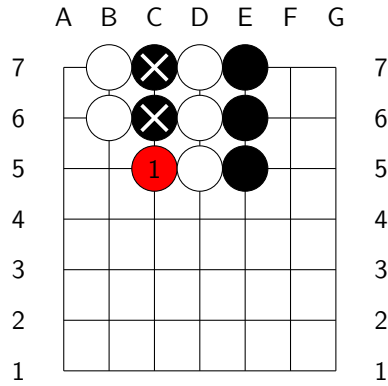
A draw is possible, although compared to chess it is unlikely (for random games on the 19×19 board especially so, as the table in Section 2.1 shows).

3. EXAMPLES

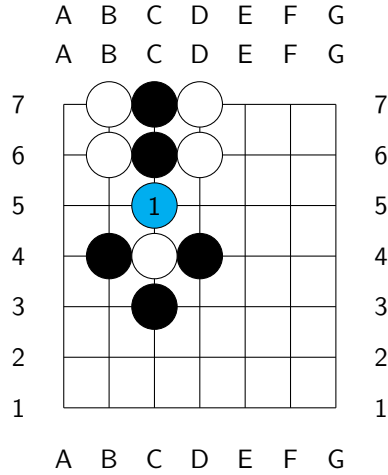
Throughout, a turn's joint move is written m/m' , the move of the first player listed first – in *SGo*, Black's.

3.1. Capture and non capture moves. Here are some examples and non examples of capture.

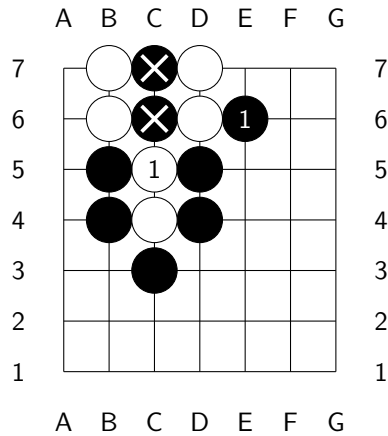
Turn 1 is $C5/C5$. This is a capture move, and C5 will resolve to white at the end of the turn.



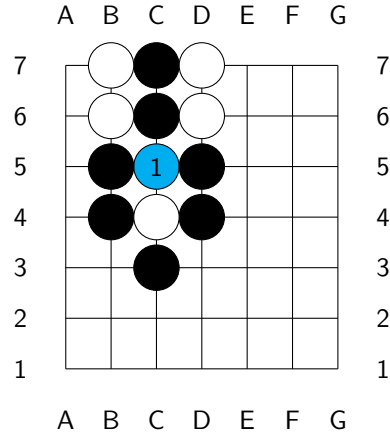
The turn is again $C5/C5$, in another display: not a capture move, as the created q-stone, marked blue, is adjacent to an opposite-colored trapped component. This should make intuitive sense since any capture would be ambiguous from a classical *Go* perspective.



Turn 1 is $E6/C5$. White's move is a capture move, as Condition **3b** is satisfied. This is consistent with classical *Go* behavior that suicidal captures resolve to capture.

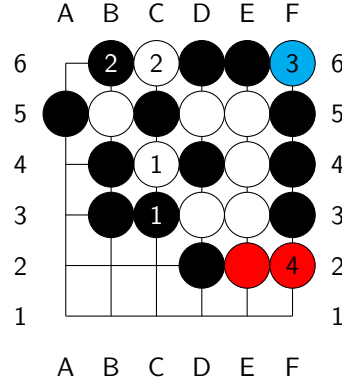


The turn is $C5/C5$: not a capture move, since Condition **3b** is now not satisfied, the stone placed on this turn being a q-stone (marked blue, as the blocker).

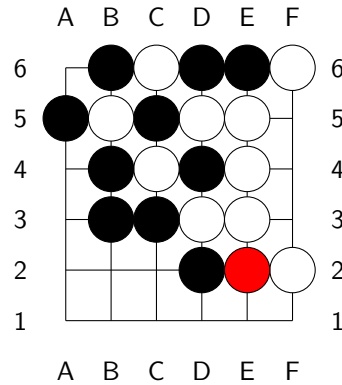


3.2. More complex examples.

In the display on the right, turn 1 is $C3/C4$ – Black attempts capture at C3, White at C4. Nothing is captured on turn 1 according to our rules, and after turn 2 we get a display with captures blocked across turns. The resolution below cascades through the stages. The continuation $B6/C6$; $F6/F6$; $F2/F2$ is indicated. Note that F6 is not a capture for White under our rules, similar to the last example of the previous section; F6 is marked blue, being what blocks the capture of D6 and E6 on this turn. But F2 is a capture move for White since condition **3a** is satisfied.

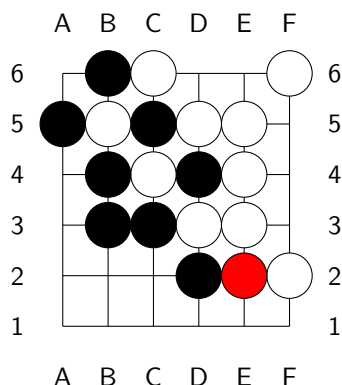


At the end of turn 4, the capture reduction is depicted on the right.



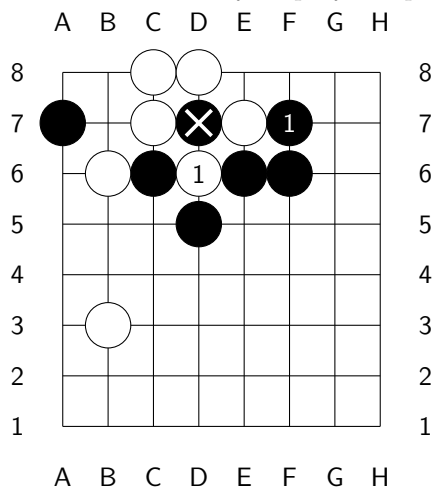
Stage two reduction. Stage three, which applies the capture conditions of turn 2, removes nothing: C5 and B5 each block the other's capture. So the recursion stops, and this is the final resolution of turn 4.

Note that B5, C5, C4 and D4 are all trapped yet uncaptured – an entangled analogue of *seki*, impossible in classical *Go*: each capture is blocked across turns 1 by the others.

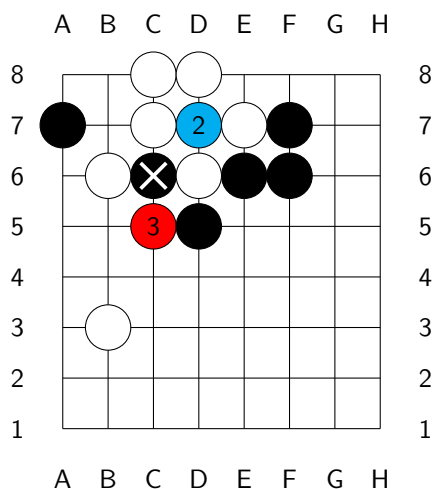


3.2.1. *Ko situation.* Below is a *Ko* type situation. Recall that we do not have a *Ko* rule; none is needed, since the display cannot immediately loop by recapture.

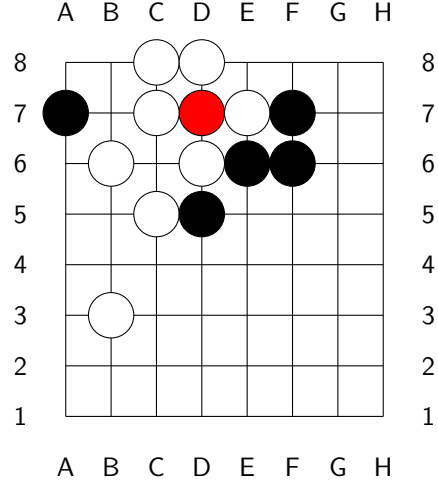
Turn 1 is *F7/D6*; White's *D6* is a capture move.



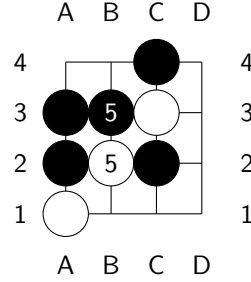
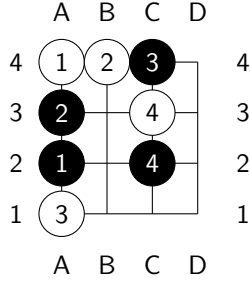
Here is the possible continuation *D7/D7*; *C5/C5*; the blue stone at *D7* is what blocks Black's recapture of White's *D6*.



At the end of turn 3 we get the following display: the q-stone at D7 simply persists. The Ko fight remains open.



3.3. Component clause firing. Here is an example where the component clause of the suicidal capture condition **3b** – that the trapped neighbor’s *component* contain a stone created on this turn – does the work. On the 4×4 board play the conflict-free history $A2/A4$; $A3/B4$; $C4/A1$; $C2/C3$:



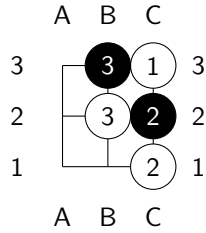
Now play $B3/B2$. Black’s B3 fills the last liberty of the old white pair A4, B4, while White’s B2 fills the last liberty of the black group A2, A3, B3. The black group is trapped by White on this turn, so condition **3a** fails for the pair and the suicidal capture clause governs. The pair touches the trapped group at A3 – an old stone – but the group *contains* this turn’s B3: condition **3b** is met, and the pair is captured, as the right board shows.

This is what the classical semantics demands: the two serializations of the turn agree, and each captures the pair – B3 played first captures it at once, and B2 then lands with the liberty B1; B2 played first, B3 still captures it, the black group surviving on the freed liberties. Formally, condition **3b** is necessitated by condition **4** of Definition 4.17 of simultaneization, see also the preamble of the proof of Lemma 5.3.

3.4. Quantum effects. It helps here to use branch semantics from the formalization of Section 4.1; the rules themselves never consult that formalization, and the reader may ignore it on first reading.

The branches of the entanglement state can interact through the display; we might call these quantum effects.

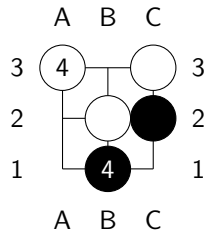
On the 3×3 board play the history pass/ $C3$; $C2/C1$; $B3/B2$, arriving at the display:



Both $C3$ and $C2$ are trapped yet uncaptured.

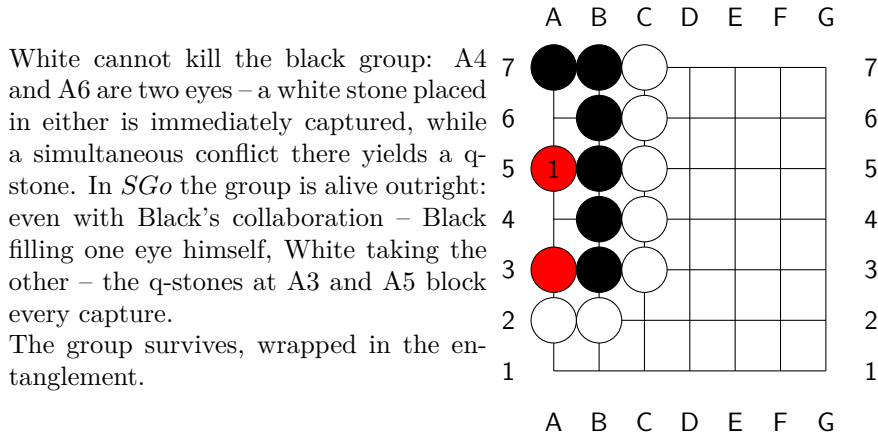
In one branch of the entanglement Black's $B3$ has captured $C3$; in the other White's $B2$ has captured $C2$. This is a standoff on pure black and white stones, with no q-stone anywhere in the history.

Now play the joint move $B1/A3$. The displayed resolution captures both $B3$ and $C1$:

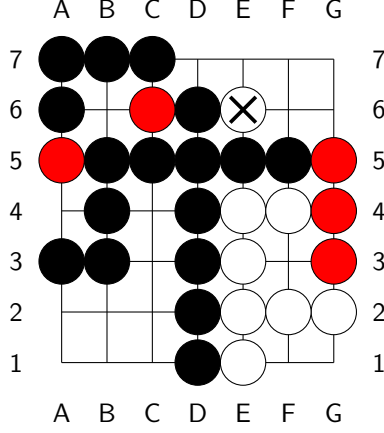


though in each branch only one of them is captured. OR thus performs a joint capture that no serialization of the history performs. In the universal simultaneization of Section 4.4 the branches never interact: its evolution is the union of independent classical evolutions.

3.5. Life and death. Life and death is positionally very similar to *Go*; here is an example.



3.6. End game scoring. In the diagram below, the players have agreed to end the game. The white stone at E6 is agreed to be dead, and is removed before counting. White has $7+3$ points and Black has $7 \cdot 7 - (7+3) - 5$ points, where the -5 accounts for the five q-stones, which count for neither player.



4. SYMMETRIC SIMULTANEOUS COMBINATORIAL GAMES

We will use the formalism of automata as it is very flexible. The goal is to introduce symmetric simultaneous combinatorial games. Such formalisms are standard in several communities: games with simultaneous moves appear as the deterministic case of the stochastic games of Shapley [28], and as the concurrent game structures of computer science [1]. Simultaneous play of combinatorial games as such is studied by Huggan–Nowakowski–Ottaway [11], see also the references therein; there, however, the effect of a pair of simultaneous moves must be specified by each ruleset separately, no general procedure being available. The emphasis here, on simultaneizations of a given sequential game and on their simplicity, appears to be new, and in this setting the pass moves together with the operation $\#$ further below do furnish such a general procedure. The inverse passage, representing a sequential game within an intrinsically simultaneous formalism, is standard in general game playing, and is likewise effected by pass-like moves: there the idle player is required to play an explicit “noop” move, cf. [29].

Definition 4.1. A *combinatorial simultaneous game* (with a pass move) G with 2 players P_0, P_1 consists of:

- A deterministic automaton G , whose set of states is a set $S(G)$ called the set of game states of G .
- The alphabet (that is the set of moves) is a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ graded finite set $M(G) = M_0(G) \cup M_1(G)$: interpreted as possible moves of the players.
- $M_0(G) \cap M_1(G)$ has one move denoted as 0 and called the *pass move* (it has multi grading both 0 and 1).
- Game states decompose as

$$S(G) = B(G) \sqcup B(G) \times M(G),$$

where $B(G)$ is some set, its elements the between-turn states.

- Nonempty subset $F(G) = W_0(G) \sqcup W_1(G) \sqcup D(G) \subset S(G)$ of final (accepting) states, which are understood as states where P_0 wins, P_1 wins or both players draw, respectively.
- A distinguished initial state $q_0 \in B(G)$, understood as the state in which the game is initialized.
- A partial game evolution function:

$$E = E_G : S(G) \times M(G) \rightarrow S(G),$$

which has the properties:

- (1) $E(s, m)$ is undefined for s in one of the final states.
- (2) If $s \in B(G) \subset S(G)$, then $E(s, m) = (s, m)$ for all $m \in M(G)$ s.t. $E(s, m)$ is defined.
- (3) If s is not final, $E(s, 0)$ is defined.
- (4) If $(s, m) \in B(G) \times M(G)$, then $E((s, m), m') \in B(G)$ if defined, and is undefined if the grading of m is the grading of m' (and if neither m nor m' is 0).
- (5) Suppose that $m_0 \in M_0(G)$, $m_1 \in M_1(G)$, $s \in B(G)$, $E(s, m_0)$ is defined and $E(s, m_1)$ is defined, then $E(s, m_0, m_1)$ is defined.
- (6) For s, m_0, m_1 as in the previous property, if $E(s, m_0, m_1)$ is defined then so is $E(s, m_1, m_0)$ and

$$E(s, m_0, m_1) = E(s, m_1, m_0).$$

We recursively define:

$$E(s, m_1, \dots, m_k) = E(E(s, m_1, \dots, m_{k-1}), m_k).$$

We say that G is **finite** if $S(G)$, $M(G)$ are finite, and all game histories have bounded length, where a game history is a sequence $h = \{m_i\}_{i=1}^n$ of moves s.t.

$$\forall 1 \leq k \leq n \ E(q_0, m_1, \dots, m_k) \text{ is defined.}$$

Note that any game history of length $2k$ can be rewritten in the form $h = \{m_i^0, m_i^1\}_{i=1}^k$, with $m_i^j \in M_j(G)$.

It is our convention that $S(G)$ is the set of legally obtainable states, that is states of the form $E(q_0, m_1, \dots, m_k)$, for some m_i .

The above notion is more interesting when G also satisfies a certain symmetry between the two players.

Definition 4.2. We say that a combinatorial simultaneous game G is **symmetric** if the following conditions are satisfied.

- (1) There is a bijection $\mathcal{A} : M(G) \rightarrow M(G)$ taking $M_0(G)$ onto $M_1(G)$, and satisfying $\mathcal{A}^2 = id$, $\mathcal{A}(0) = 0$.
- (2) There is a bijection $\mathcal{R} : B(G) \rightarrow B(G)$, satisfying $\mathcal{R}^2 = id$ and $\mathcal{R}(q_0) = q_0$, which we extend to $\mathcal{R} : S(G) \rightarrow S(G)$ by $\mathcal{R}(s, m) = (\mathcal{R}(s), \mathcal{A}(m))$, s.t. for all $s \in S(G)$, all $m \in M(G)$, and for $\mathcal{A}$ as above we have:
 - $\mathcal{R} \circ E(\mathcal{R}(s), \mathcal{A}(m)) = E(s, m)$, whenever both sides are defined. Furthermore, if one side is defined then so is the other.
 - $\mathcal{R}$ also induces a bijection from $W_0(G)$ onto $W_1(G)$ and $D(G)$ onto $D(G)$.

4.1. Formalizing SGo . A state s of SGo is a pair. The first member is the display, as maintained by the rules of Section 2, its time stamps included. The second is the *entanglement state* $\rho(s)$, briefly the *entanglement*: a finite set of classical Go states, called *branches* – the classical states that the play so far may have produced. Note that this is decorative: it is extra data we choose to baggage for reasons that will be apparent soon. The game rules themselves are completely display driven; the player does not care about this baggage. Later we introduce a variant game $DSGo$ whose game evolution does consult the entanglement.

The initial entanglement state is the singleton of the empty state. On a turn, first each branch evolves as a classical Go state: the two moves of the turn are played on it in both orders, a move to an occupied intersection forfeited, and the outcomes are collected. The display is resolved by the rules of Section 2, and the resolved display prunes: the new entanglement state consists of the collected branches *compatible* with it. Compatible means: every stone of the branch stands on an occupied intersection of the display, and matches the color of the displayed stone there, a q-stone matching either color.

Lemma 4.3. *SGo is an ssc game, that is a symmetric simultaneous combinatorial game.*

Proof. Set $G = SGo$. The set $M_0(G)$ corresponds to possible moves of Black and $M_1(G)$ the moves of White, as in the game description, with the pass move 0 the standard pass move.

The state space is:

$$S(G) = B(G) \sqcup B(G) \times M(G),$$

where an element of $B(G)$ is the full data maintained by the rules of Section 2: the display with its time stamps, together with the entanglement state of Section 4.1 – a finite set of legally obtainable states of Go . The initial state is the empty display with the entanglement $\{q_0\}$, for q_0 the empty state.

The evolution map E is then naturally defined. For example if $s \in B(G)$ and $m_0 \in M_0(G)$, $m_1 \in M_1(G)$ are moves to empty intersections of the display, then $E((s, m_0), m_1) \in B(G)$ is defined to be the state produced by the rules of Section 2: the display resolves by the placement rule and the objective reduction. Each branch evolves under the serialized moves, and the branches incompatible with the resolved display are discarded.

To see that G is symmetric, let $\mathcal{R} : B(G) \rightarrow B(G)$ be the map that interchanges the black and white colors of the stones in every branch (on the display this interchanges black and white and leaves q-stones invariant). And let $\mathcal{A} : M(G) \rightarrow M(G)$ interchange black and white moves, i.e. we have a natural isomorphism $M_0(G) \rightarrow M_1(G)$, which then induces $\mathcal{A}$. Then clearly the conditions of Definition 4.2 will be satisfied. $\square$

Remark 4.4. *We have not formalized $F(SGo)$: ending a game by agreement is not an automaton notion. This caveat is however minor, and is already present in classical Go . For the theorems of Section 5 the automaton convention is fixed there: a state is final exactly after a double pass turn.*

4.2. Solvability. A theorem of Zermelo [27] says that for every finite sequential game either Black or White has a winning strategy or there is a draw strategy. Clearly SGo cannot have a winning strategy: mirroring a winning strategy via the

symmetry operators would yield one for the opponent, and both players cannot win. Furthermore, unless we put an upper bound on the length of a game, or on the number of state repetitions, an *SGo* game can be infinitely long.⁴ So we will assume there is such a bound, which will make *SGo* a finite game.

One may ask whether *SGo* has a *strategy to draw*: a pure strategy guaranteeing at least a draw. On the 2×2 board it does, with a caveat: here we drop the game length bound and count an unending game as drawn. In this sense, exact computation shows that both players can force at least a draw. Neither player can force the game to end: the drawing strategies are locks, not finishes. But already on the 3×3 board, with any bound between 6 and 8, neither player has such a strategy: a player following any fixed pure strategy can be made to lose. Optimal play is thus necessarily mixed from the 3×3 board on, and we expect the same on all larger boards – the mixed equilibrium of Theorem 4.5 below is not a formality.

Theorem 4.5. *For any assignment of payoffs to a win, a loss and a draw, a finite combinatorial simultaneous game G (Definition 4.1) has a Nash equilibrium.*

Proof. For a non final $s \in B(G)$ set

$$I_i(s) = \{m \in M_i(G) \mid E(s, m) \text{ is defined}\},$$

which is nonempty as it contains the pass move 0.

A **pure strategy** of player P_i assigns to each non final $s \in B(G)$ a move in $I_i(s)$, so that the set of pure strategies is the finite set

$$\Sigma_i = \prod_s I_i(s),$$

the product over the non final elements of $B(G)$. A pair of pure strategies determines a play of the game, and so a payoff, by finiteness of G .⁵ This presents G in normal form: a finite two-player game with the strategy sets Σ_0, Σ_1 . The mixed strategies of player P_i are then $\mathcal{P}_i = \Delta(\Sigma_i)$, the probability distributions over Σ_i . The theorem is now a direct application of the Nash existence theorem [19]. $\square$

Corollary 4.6. *A finite ssc game G has a strategy to draw on average, and in particular *SGo* has such a strategy.*

Proof. Assign 1 for a win, -1 for a loss and 0 for a draw. By the normal form presentation in the proof of Theorem 4.5, G is a zero sum matrix payoff game, with the rows and columns of the payoff matrix indexed by the pure strategies Σ_0, Σ_1 . By the classical theory of matrix payoff games (see for instance [20]), all Nash equilibria have the same expected payoff for Black, namely the value v of the matrix game, and an equilibrium strategy of Black guarantees Black an expected payoff of at least v against every strategy of White. So it is enough to show that $v = 0$; that a symmetric zero sum game has value zero is classical, cf. [9], and for completeness we give the argument.

Suppose otherwise, and suppose without loss of generality that $v > 0$, so that for an equilibrium joint strategy

$$(\mathcal{D}_0, \mathcal{D}_1) \in \mathcal{P}_0 \times \mathcal{P}_1$$

Black has expected payoff $v > 0$.

⁴This is also true for *Go* and chess.

⁵Possibly the finiteness condition can be relaxed.

Let $\mathcal{R}, \mathcal{A}$ be the symmetry operators as in the proof of Lemma 4.3. Naturally applying these operators to the joint strategy $(\mathcal{D}_0, \mathcal{D}_1)$ we get an equilibrium joint strategy $(\mathcal{D}'_0, \mathcal{D}'_1)$ where White has expected payoff v , that is with Black expected payoff $-v < 0$. As the latter must again be v , we have a contradiction. $\square$

4.3. Symmetric combinatorial sequential games. Combinatorial sequential games have a beautiful Conway recursive definition [4]. However, for our purpose, in particular for the universal simultaneization construction, it is convenient to interpret them in terms of finite automata.

Definition 4.7. A *combinatorial sequential game* (with a pass move) G with 2 players P_0, P_1 is presented by its core:

- The alphabet (that is the set of moves) is a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ graded finite set $M(G) = M_0(G) \cup M_1(G)$: interpreted as possible moves of the players.
- $M_0(G) \cap M_1(G)$ has one move denoted as 0 and called the *pass move* (it has multi grading both 0 and 1).
- A set $C(G)$ of *core states*, with a distinguished initial core state x_0 .
- A partial action of the non pass moves on the core states:

$$E_C = E_{C,G} : C(G) \times (M(G) - \{0\}) \rightarrow C(G).$$

- A subset of $C(G)$ of core states *ended by play*: the core states with a captured king in *chess* below, none for *Go*.
- A partition $F(G) = W_0(G) \sqcup W_1(G) \sqcup D(G)$ of the final states, defined next, understood as states where P_0 wins, P_1 wins or both players draw, respectively.

The game states are then defined. A *live state* is a triple (x, i, j) : a core state x with a *turn grading* $i \in \mathbb{Z}_2$ and a *pass grading* $j \in \mathbb{Z}_2$; we write $S_{i,j}(G)$ for the set of live states of bigrading (i, j) . A *final* (accepting) *state* is a pair (x, i) : a core state with a turn grading. The set of game states is

$$S(G) = \bigsqcup_{i,j} S_{i,j}(G) \sqcup F(G),$$

$F(G)$ the set of final states. It is $\mathbb{Z}_2$ graded by the turn grading, $S(G) = S_0(G) \sqcup S_1(G)$, with $\deg : S(G) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_2$ the associated function. The initial state is $q_0 = (x_0, 0, 0) \in S_0(G)$. The partial game evolution function

$$E = E_G : S(G) \times M(G) \rightarrow S(G)$$

is defined as follows, and is undefined otherwise.

- A pass raises the pass grading, and a second consecutive pass ends the game: $E((x, i, 0), 0) = (x, i + 1, 1)$ and $E((x, i, 1), 0) = (x, i + 1) \in F(G)$.
- A non pass move m of grading i acts on the core state and resets the pass grading: for $E_C(x, m)$ defined, $E((x, i, j), m) = (E_C(x, m), i + 1, 0)$, or the final state $(E_C(x, m), i + 1)$ when $E_C(x, m)$ is ended by play.

The evolution has the following properties, by construction:

- (1) $E(s, m)$ is undefined for s in one of the final states.
- (2) $E(s, m)$ is defined only if m has the same grading as s or if $m = 0$.
- (3) If $E(s, m)$ is defined then $\deg(E(s, m)) = \deg(s) + 1$.
- (4) If s is not a final state then $E(s, 0)$ is defined.
- (5) If $E(s, 0) = E(s', 0)$ then $s = s'$.

- (6) If $E(s, 0, 0)$ is defined then it is a final state: two consecutive pass moves end the game.

We recursively define:

$$E(s, m_1, \dots, m_k) = E(E(s, m_1, \dots, m_{k-1}), m_k).$$

A state is *legally obtainable* if it is of the form $E(q_0, m_1, \dots, m_k)$, for some m_i ; it will be understood that $C(G)$ consists of the core states of legally obtainable states, and $S(G)$ of all the states over them.

Example 4.8. *Note that Go has a pass move, but chess does not; however, chess can be augmented with a pass move, by also adjusting the rules so that king capture is legal and ends the game, while also removing the check rules, and with the game ending in a tie after two consecutive passes. This does not change the early-mid game dynamics at all, but the end game does significantly change, with more tie possibilities (mainly, if a player is in Zugzwang they may just pass). We will call this **augmented chess** denoted by $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$.*

Definition 4.9. We say that a combinatorial sequential game G is **symmetric** if the following conditions are satisfied.

- (1) There is a bijection $\mathcal{A} : M(G) \rightarrow M(G)$ taking $M_0(G)$ onto $M_1(G)$ and satisfying $\mathcal{A}^2 = id$, $\mathcal{A}(0) = 0$.
- (2) There is a bijection $\mathcal{R} : C(G) \rightarrow C(G)$ of the core states, satisfying $\mathcal{R}^2 = id$ and $\mathcal{R}(x_0) = x_0$, preserving the core states ended by play, and s.t. for all $x \in C(G)$ and all non pass $m \in M(G)$:

$$\mathcal{R} \circ E_C(\mathcal{R}(x), \mathcal{A}(m)) = E_C(x, m),$$

whenever both sides are defined; furthermore, if one side is defined then so is the other. We extend $\mathcal{R}$ to the game states by $\mathcal{R}(x, i, j) = (\mathcal{R}(x), i+1, j)$ and $\mathcal{R}(x, i) = (\mathcal{R}(x), i+1)$: it takes $S_0(G)$ to $S_1(G)$, and by construction

$$\mathcal{R} \circ E(\mathcal{R}(s), \mathcal{A}(m)) = E(s, m),$$

whenever both sides are defined, one side being defined if and only if the other is.

- (3) $\mathcal{R}$ also induces a bijection from $W_0(G)$ onto $W_1(G)$ and $D(G)$ onto $D(G)$.

Example 4.10. *Of course $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$ and classical Go are examples of symmetric games. In the case of Go, $\mathcal{A}$ interchanges black and white moves and $\mathcal{R}$ interchanges the colors of the stones of a diagram (it is easy to see that this does result in a legally obtainable core state).*

It will be the assumption from now on that all sequential games that appear are symmetric (with $\mathcal{A}$, $\mathcal{R}$ implicitly fixed).

4.4. Universal simultaneization. Let G be a sequential game (by our standing assumption with a pass move 0 and symmetric). Let $\{m_i\}$ be a sequence of game moves. If some $m_i = 0$ and $m_k \neq 0$ for some $k > i$, then we say that it is an **interior pass move**. We say that a finite sequence $\{m_i\}$ of moves of G is **pseudo legal** if it becomes a game history after adding or removing some interior pass moves from the sequence.

Definition 4.11. For a state a of G set

$$\overline{(x, i, j)} = (x, i + 1, j + 1), \quad \overline{(x, i)} = (x, i + 1, 1).$$

For $m \in M(G)$ set

$$a \# m = \begin{cases} E_G(a, m), & \text{if this is defined} \\ E_G(\bar{a}, m), & \text{if this is defined} \\ \text{undefined}, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

So let m be a non pass move of grading k and $a = (x, i, j)$ a live state. Then $a \# m$ is defined exactly when $E_C(x, m)$ is, and equals $(E_C(x, m), k + 1, 0)$, or the final $(E_C(x, m), k + 1)$ at a core state ended by play: the move is played at a if $i = k$ and at $\bar{a}$ otherwise. And $a \# 0 = E_G(a, 0)$. At a final state $a = (x, i)$, $a \# m$ may be defined. No such value enters the evolution of $\text{Sim}(G)$ below, which requires non final branches, nor the faithfulness conditions, read at non final states, whose branches are non final (Lemma 4.18).

For a state b let $N(b)$, the **position normal form** of b , be $(x, 0, 0)$ for $b = (x, i, j)$ live and $(x, 0)$ for $b = (x, i)$ final: the gradings are reset, the core state kept. Two states have the same position normal form exactly when they have the same core state and are both live or both final. We write $N(S(G))$ for the set of position normal forms. A position normal form is a state over a legally obtainable core state, though not always a legally obtainable state. Define $P(a, m_0, m_1) \subseteq N(S(G))$, for $a \in S(G)$, by the following prescription in decreasing priority, where each term is understood to be replaced by its position normal form, and the expression is defined if and only if all the terms are defined.

- $P(a, m_0, m_1) := a \# m_0 \# m_1 \cup a \# m_1 \# m_0$ (note that if $m_0 = m_1 = 0$ then the two terms coincide, so that $P(a, 0, 0) = a \# 0 \# 0$.)
- $P(a, m_0, m_1) := a \# m_0 \# m_1 \cup a \# m_1$.
- $P(a, m_0, m_1) := a \# m_0 \cup a \# m_1 \# m_0$.
- $P(a, m_0, m_1) := a \# m_0 \cup a \# m_1$.
- $P(a, m_0, m_1)$ is undefined.

We then get a partial function

$$P : S(G) \times M_0(G) \times M_1(G) \rightarrow 2^{N(S(G))},$$

which we call the **serialization map**: it evaluates the turn in its available serializations – both orders of play when both are defined, the degenerate cases otherwise – and collects the outcomes. It is defined exactly when $a \# m_0$ and $a \# m_1$ are: each case has a term through $a \# m_0$ and one through $a \# m_1$, and the fourth case has nothing else.

Definition 4.12. Let G be a sequential game. Its **universal simultaneization** is the simultaneous game $\text{Sim}(G) = G'$ satisfying the following.

- (1) $B(G') = 2^{N(S(G))}$: the sets of states in position normal form. (The elements s of $\mathfrak{s} \in B(G')$ will be called **state branches**.) A live branch is determined by its core state.
- (2) The initial state $q'_0 = \{q_0\}$.
- (3) $M(G') = M(G)$ as $\mathbb{Z}_2$ graded sets.
- (4) Let $\mathfrak{s} \in B(G')$, and $m_i \in M_i(G')$; then $E_{G'}(\mathfrak{s}, m_i)$ is defined iff for each $s \in \mathfrak{s}$, s is not final and $s \# m_i$ is defined.

(5) For $\mathfrak{s}$ and m_i as just above:

$$E_{G'}(\mathfrak{s}, m_0, m_1) := \cup_{s \in \mathfrak{s}} P(s, m_0, m_1),$$

(undefined if some $P(s, m_0, m_1)$ is undefined).

(6)

$$\mathfrak{s} \in F(G') \iff \exists s \in \mathfrak{s} s \in F(G).$$

Note that $\text{Sim}(G)$ is uniquely defined by the above conditions up to the partition of its final states into W_0, W_1, D . The partition plays no role beyond the symmetry of Lemma 4.14; one may take $\mathfrak{s}$ winning for a player exactly when some branch wins for them and no branch wins for the opponent, and drawn otherwise.

We do not impose the obtainability convention on $\text{Sim}(G)$: $B(\text{Sim}(G))$ is the entire power set. In particular the empty set is a state, non final and with every move available, by the conditions above. It is unreachable within $\text{Sim}(G)$ itself; the branch semantics of Definition 4.17 may reach it.

Remark 4.13. *The passage from states to sets of states is a form of the classical subset construction of automata theory [23]. In game theoretic terms, a state of $\text{Sim}(G)$ is a knowledge state: the set of classical states consistent with what the players have observed. Analogous knowledge based constructions are used in the study of games of imperfect information, see for instance [25], [6].*

Lemma 4.14. *$\text{Sim}(G)$ is symmetric.*

Proof. Set $G' = \text{Sim}(G)$, and let $\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{R}$ be the symmetry operators of G . Set $\tilde{\mathcal{A}} : M(G') \rightarrow M(G')$ to just be $\mathcal{A}$. For

$$\{s_0, \dots, s_k\} = \mathfrak{s} \in B(G'),$$

set

$$\tilde{\mathcal{R}}(\mathfrak{s}) = \{\mathcal{R}(s_0), \dots, \mathcal{R}(s_k)\},$$

with each $\mathcal{R}(s_i)$ replaced by its position normal form, $\mathcal{R}$ being grading reversing. Since $\mathcal{A}(0) = 0$, the map $\mathcal{R}$ commutes with the pass move; and it acts on the core state, so it commutes with the position normal form up to the turn grading. It follows that $\tilde{\mathcal{R}}^2 = \text{id}$ exactly, and that the computation below is unaffected by the normalization. Indeed, let $a = (x, i, 0)$ and $a' = (x, i + 1, 0)$; for a live branch s , $\mathcal{R}(s)$ and $N(\mathcal{R}(s))$ are such a pair. By the formula for $\#$ after Definition 4.11, $a \# m = a' \# m$ for $m \neq 0$; $a \# 0 = (x, i + 1, 1)$ and $a' \# 0 = (x, i, 1)$ again differ only in the turn grading; and a further pass lands at the finals (x, i) and $(x, i + 1)$, of one position normal form. So $P(a, m_0, m_1) = P(a', m_0, m_1)$. For

$$(\mathfrak{s}, m) \in B(G') \times M(G') \subset S(G'),$$

set

$$\tilde{\mathcal{R}}(\mathfrak{s}, m) = (\tilde{\mathcal{R}}(\mathfrak{s}), \tilde{\mathcal{A}}(m)).$$

The needed symmetry properties for the maps $\tilde{\mathcal{A}}, \tilde{\mathcal{R}}$ are then verified using the symmetry properties of $\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{R}$ as follows. It is easily seen that $\overline{\mathcal{R}(a)} = \mathcal{R}(\bar{a})$, hence

$$\mathcal{R}(a) \# \mathcal{A}(m) = \begin{cases} E_G(\mathcal{R}(a), \mathcal{A}(m)) = \mathcal{R} \circ E_G(a, m), & \text{if defined} \\ E_G(\mathcal{R}(\bar{a}), \mathcal{A}(m)) = \mathcal{R} \circ E_G(\bar{a}, m), & \text{if defined} \end{cases}$$

and so

$$(4.15) \quad \mathcal{R}(a) \# \mathcal{A}(m) = \mathcal{R}(a \# m),$$

furthermore if one side is defined then so is the other. Suppose that $\mathfrak{s} \in B(G')$ and $m_i \in M_i(G')$; then we get:

$$\begin{aligned} \tilde{\mathcal{R}}(E_{G'}(\tilde{\mathcal{R}}(\mathfrak{s}), \tilde{\mathcal{A}}(m_0), \tilde{\mathcal{A}}(m_1))) &= \tilde{\mathcal{R}} \circ \cup_{s \in \mathfrak{s}} P(\mathcal{R}(s), \mathcal{A}(m_0), \mathcal{A}(m_1)) \\ &= \tilde{\mathcal{R}} \circ \cup_{s \in \mathfrak{s}} \mathcal{R} \circ P(s, m_0, m_1) \text{ using (4.15)} \\ &= \cup_{s \in \mathfrak{s}} P(s, m_0, m_1) \\ &= E_{G'}(\mathfrak{s}, m_0, m_1), \end{aligned}$$

furthermore if one side is defined then so is the other. This verifies property 2 of Definition 4.2 for pair moves at states of $B(G')$; the rest is similar. $\square$

Definition 4.16. Let G_0 be a sequential game and G_1 a symmetric simultaneous game with $M(G_1) = M(G_0)$. The **semi-classical** states of G_1 , with their **associated states** in G_0 , are defined recursively: the initial state of G_1 is semi-classical, with associated state the initial state of G_0 . If s is semi-classical with associated state a , and m_0, m_1 commute at a – both $a \# m_0 \# m_1$ and $a \# m_1 \# m_0$ are defined, with the same position normal form – then $E_{G_1}(s, m_0, m_1)$, if defined, is semi-classical, with associated state the common position normal form of $a \# m_0 \# m_1$ and $a \# m_1 \# m_0$. A history of commuting turns witnessing this recursion we call a *generating history* of the state it reaches.

Definition 4.17. Let G_0 be a sequential game. We say that G_1 is a **simultaneization** of G_0 if the following is satisfied.

- (1) G_1 is a symmetric simultaneous game.
- (2) $M(G_1) = M(G_0)$ as $\mathbb{Z}_2$ graded sets.
- (3) There is a map $\rho : B(G_1) \rightarrow B(\text{Sim}(G_0))$ – the *branch semantics* – satisfying $\rho(q_0) = q'_0$ and s.t. for $s \in B(G_1)$: whenever the state $E_{G_1}(s, m_0, m_1)$ is defined, so is $E_{\text{Sim}(G_0)}(\rho(s), m_0, m_1)$, and

$$\rho(E_{G_1}(s, m_0, m_1)) \subset E_{\text{Sim}(G_0)}(\rho(s), m_0, m_1).$$

- (4) For every semi-classical s with associated state a (Definition 4.16): $\rho(s) = \{a\}$.

For $a \in S(G_0)$ set

$$\mathbb{I}(a) = \{m \in M(G_0) \mid a \# m \text{ is defined}\},$$

which we call the **interface** of the state a : the set of moves of either player available at a , with the operation $\#$ absorbing the turn order. Likewise, for $s \in B(G_1)$ set $I(s) = \{m \in M(G_1) \mid E_{G_1}(s, m) \text{ is defined}\}$, the interface of the state s .

Lemma 4.18. Let G_1 be a simultaneization of G_0 . Then for every non final $s \in B(G_1)$: every branch of $\rho(s)$ is non final, and

$$I(s) \subseteq \bigcap_{a \in \rho(s)} \mathbb{I}(a).$$

That is, a move available at s is available in every branch. Equality of the two sides, together with $\rho(s) \neq \emptyset$, is precisely the statement that a joint move is available at s if and only if it is available in $\text{Sim}(G_0)$ at $\rho(s)$.

Proof. First, for $m \in M(G_1)$, $E_{G_1}(s, m)$ is defined if and only if the pair move $E_{G_1}(s, m, 0)$ (in the order of the pair prescribed by the grading of m) is defined. Indeed, the latter presupposes the former, and conversely if $E_{G_1}(s, m)$ is defined then so is $E_{G_1}(s, 0)$, as s is not final, and so by the properties of Definition 4.1 the pair move is defined, using that the pass move has both gradings. If some $a \in \rho(s)$ were final, then no joint move would be defined in $\text{Sim}(G_0)$ at $\rho(s)$, by the construction of $\text{Sim}(G_0)$; by condition 3 no joint move would then be defined at s , contradicting the definedness of the pair $(0, 0)$ at the non final s . So every branch is non final. Now if $m \in I(s)$, the pair move is defined at s , hence, by condition 3, defined in $\text{Sim}(G_0)$ at $\rho(s)$, which says exactly that $a \# m$ and $a \# 0$ are defined for every $a \in \rho(s)$, that is $m \in \mathbb{I}(a)$ for every a . The equality statement is the same unwinding read in both directions. $\square$

Definition 4.19. Let G_1 be a simultaneization of G_0 . We say that G_1 is **faithful** at a state $s \in B(G_1)$ if $\rho(s)$ is nonempty, s is final only if some branch of $\rho(s)$ is final, and, when s is not final,

$$I(s) = \bigcap_{a \in \rho(s)} \mathbb{I}(a),$$

that is, exactly the joint moves of $\text{Sim}(G_0)$ at $\rho(s)$ are available at s . The finality clause says that G_1 may not invent endings where it is faithful. For $d \geq 0$, we say that G_1 is **faithful within distance d of classical play** if it is faithful at every state reachable from a semi-classical state in at most d turns, distance 0 being the semi-classical states themselves. The **faithfulness radius** of G_1 is the supremum of the d such that G_1 is faithful within distance d of classical play, possibly 0 or ∞ : the depth to which its branch semantics stays exact. It is defined when G_1 is faithful within distance 0; otherwise G_1 has no radius.

Definition 4.20. Let G_0 be a sequential game. We will say that a simultaneization G_1 of G_0 is a **simple simultaneization of G_0** if for every non final $s \in B(G_1)$ at which a non pass move is available there is a legally obtainable state $a \in S(G_0)$ with

$$\mathbb{I}(a) = I(s),$$

where for s the initial state of G_1 , a can be taken to be q_0 . The **radius spectrum** of G_0 is the set of faithfulness radii of its simple simultaneizations, a subset of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$; a simultaneization with no radius contributes nothing. The **absolute radius** of G_0 is the supremum of its radius spectrum.

The radii and the radius spectrum are dynamical isomorphism invariants in the sense of the following.

Lemma 4.21. *Let G_0, G'_0 be sequential games, and let φ be a bijection of their core states and of their graded moves intertwining the actions of the non pass moves, the initial core states and the core states ended by play; extend it to the game states by $\varphi(x, i, j) = (\varphi(x), i, j)$ and $\varphi(x, i) = (\varphi(x), i)$. Then:*

- (1) *φ intertwines the evolutions, the pass moves, the final states and the position normal forms.*
- (2) *If H is a simultaneization of G_0 , then renaming each move m of H to $\varphi(m)$ yields a simultaneization H' of G'_0 , isomorphic to H over φ . The faithfulness radii of H and H' coincide, and H' is simple if and only if H is.*

- (3) *The radius spectra of G_0 and G'_0 coincide; in particular so do the absolute radii. The spectrum is independent of the scoring: repartitioning the final states into W_0, W_1, D does not change it.*

Proof. (1) A bijection of graded moves carries $M_0(G_0) \cap M_1(G_0)$ onto $M_0(G'_0) \cap M_1(G'_0)$; each intersection consists of the pass move. The evolution, the final states and the position normal form are built from the core data and the gradings, Definition 4.7, which φ preserves.

(2) By (1), φ intertwines the operation $\#$ and the serialization map P : they are built from the evolutions, the pass moves, the gradings and the position normal form. Hence φ induces an isomorphism $\text{Sim}(\varphi) : \text{Sim}(G_0) \rightarrow \text{Sim}(G'_0)$, acting on a branch set elementwise. Let H' be H with each move m renamed to $\varphi(m)$: the same states, the evolution and the symmetric structure carried along, and the branch reduction $\rho' = \text{Sim}(\varphi) \circ \rho$. The conditions of Definition 4.17 for (H', ρ') are those for (H, ρ) , transported: the semi-classical recursion of H' relative to G'_0 is that of H relative to G_0 , with associated states $\varphi(a)$, so $\rho'(s) = \{\varphi(a)\}$ there. The identity on states, with φ on moves, is then an isomorphism over φ . Interfaces satisfy $I_{H'}(s) = \varphi(I_H(s))$ and $\mathbb{I}(\varphi(a)) = \varphi(\mathbb{I}(a))$; finality in H' is finality in H ; distances of classical play are turn counts. So the faithfulness conditions of Definition 4.19 hold at s in H' if and only if they hold in H , and the radii coincide. For simplicity: a legally obtainable witness a for s in G_0 maps to the legally obtainable witness $\varphi(a)$ in G'_0 , with $\mathbb{I}(\varphi(a)) = I_{H'}(s)$; symmetrically for φ^{-1} . Nothing above reads the partition of the final states into wins and draws.

(3) By (2) applied to φ and to φ^{-1} , the simple simultaneizations of G_0 and of G'_0 realize the same radii; the spectra coincide, and with them the suprema. For the scoring statement apply the lemma to the identity bijection. $\square$

5. MAIN THEOREMS

5.1. The decoherent variant $DSGo$. We now introduce a theoretical variant $DSGo$ ⁶: SGo with the objective reduction preempted by decoherence. Each turn, the stones are placed by the placement rule of SGo , and nothing else is played out on the display. The resulting state is then postprocessed as follows. The display is measured against the branch evolution of the turn; the entanglement does the measuring and the removing. A state of $DSGo$ carries the same data as one of SGo – a display together with its entanglement state $\rho(s)$ – and moves are available as in SGo .

The serialization map extends to sets of classical states elementwise,

$$P(\mathfrak{B}, m_0, m_1) = \bigcup_{a \in \mathfrak{B}} P(a, m_0, m_1);$$

we call $P(\rho(s), m_0, m_1)$ the *decoherence* of the turn m_0/m_1 at s .

For an intersection i and a classical state b , let $ev_i(b) \subseteq \{\text{black}, \text{white}\}$ be the color of the stone of b at i , the empty set if i is empty in b . Extend ev_i to a set of classical states by union, and to a display, or a state carrying one, by reading the display, a q-stone contributing $\{\text{black}, \text{white}\}$. The *diagram* of x – a classical state, a display, or a state carrying one – is the function $\text{diagram}(x) : i \mapsto ev_i(x)$ on the intersections of the board. Equality of diagrams is equality of stone patterns, q-stones included.

⁶ D stands for decoherence. Not meant to be humanly playable without computer resolution.

Next, the *postprocessing* $\Delta(s, \mathfrak{M})$ of a state s of $DSGo$ by a finite set $\mathfrak{M}$ of classical states, anchored at the current turn, is defined as follows. Set D_0 the display of s and $\mathfrak{M}_0 = \mathfrak{M}$. Proceed recursively; for $j \geq 0$, postprocessing round j removes from D_j the stones at the intersections i with $ev_i(\mathfrak{M}_j) = \emptyset$. A q-stone of D_j created on this turn, at an intersection i with $ev_i(\mathfrak{M}_j) = \{c\}$, becomes a c stone. This gives D_{j+1} .

Based on D_{j+1} the entanglement is then re-cut:

$$\mathfrak{M}_{j+1} = \{b \in \mathfrak{M}_j \mid \forall i : ev_i(D_{j+1}) = \emptyset \implies ev_i(b) = \emptyset\}.$$

The recursion stops at the first j with $D_{j+1} = D_j$; such a j exists as infinite descent is impossible.

Then $\Delta(s, \mathfrak{M})$ has display D_{j+1} and entanglement state $\mathfrak{M}_{j+1}$. The evolution of $DSGo$ is the postprocessed placement:

$$E_{DSGo}(s, m_0, m_1) = \Delta(\text{Pl}(s, m_0, m_1), P(\rho(s), m_0, m_1)),$$

where $\text{Pl}(s, m_0, m_1)$ is s with the turn's stones placed by the placement rule of SGo and no objective reduction applied. The preemption is forced. Were the objective reduction to act first, its captures standing, every element of the decoherence could be lost in the re-cut; faithfulness would then fail at distance two.

The postprocessing loses no element of the decoherence: an element of $\rho(s)$ occupies only display-occupied intersections – the re-cut keeps nothing else – a placement empties no intersection, and classical play otherwise only removes stones; so every element of the decoherence satisfies the hypothesis of Lemma 5.1(1) below, and survives. Hence $\rho \circ E_{DSGo} = E_{\text{Sim}(Go)} \circ \rho$: the entanglement component of a $DSGo$ history is a $\text{Sim}(Go)$ history. $DSGo$ referees $\text{Sim}(Go)$ on a display, differing from it only in scoring: the winner is decided as in SGo , Section 2.6, from the display.

The construction interpolates. For $k \geq 1$, the delayed game k - $DSGo$ stays the execution of the objective reduction for k turns. Formally, the objective reduction $D \mapsto OR(D)$ of Section 2.5, anchored at the current turn, only removes stones and converts q-stones. The *verdict* $\text{ver}(D)$ is the difference: the set of stones of D removed in $OR(D)$, and the set of q-stones of D made definite in $OR(D)$, with their acquired colors. For a verdict v , the execution $v \cdot D'$ removes and recolors accordingly the stones of D' that v names, a stone being named by its intersection and its time stamp; named stones no longer standing in D' are ignored.

A state of k - $DSGo$ is a tuple $(D, \mathfrak{M}, v_1, \dots, v_k)$: a display, an entanglement state, and the verdicts of the last k turns, v_1 the oldest. The initial state is that of $DSGo$ with all k verdicts empty. Moves, scoring, and finality are those of $DSGo$, read from D and $\mathfrak{M}$. The evolution is

$$E_k((D, \mathfrak{M}, v_1, \dots, v_k), m_0, m_1) = (D', \mathfrak{M}', v_2, \dots, v_k, \text{ver}(D')),$$

$$(D', \mathfrak{M}') = \Delta(\text{Pl}((v_1 \cdot D, \mathfrak{M}), m_0, m_1), P(\mathfrak{M}, m_0, m_1)) :$$

the oldest verdict is executed, the turn is then a turn of $DSGo$, and the new verdict is stored. Verdicts still pending when the game ends are discarded: the display is scored as it stands. As $k \rightarrow \infty$ no verdict ever executes, and the game is $DSGo$; SGo , which plays its OR at once and carries no decoherence, stands at the origin of the hierarchy.

Lemma 5.1. *Let s be a state of $DSGo$ and $\mathfrak{M}$ a finite set of classical states.*

- (1) If $b_0 \in \mathfrak{M}$ satisfies, for every intersection i , $ev_i(s) = \emptyset \implies ev_i(b_0) = \emptyset$, then $b_0 \in \rho(\Delta(s, \mathfrak{M}))$.
- (2) For every intersection i : $ev_i(\Delta(s, \mathfrak{M})) = \emptyset \iff ev_i(\rho(\Delta(s, \mathfrak{M}))) = \emptyset$.

Proof. In the rounds $(D_j, \mathfrak{M}_j)$ defining $\Delta(s, \mathfrak{M})$ – the recoloring does not change occupancy and plays no role – for (1) we show by induction on j : $b_0 \in \mathfrak{M}_j$, and $ev_i(D_j) = \emptyset \implies ev_i(b_0) = \emptyset$ for all i . For $j = 0$ this is the hypothesis. For the step: an intersection emptied by round $j + 1$ has $ev_i(\mathfrak{M}_j) = \emptyset$, and $ev_i(b_0) \subseteq ev_i(\mathfrak{M}_j)$ since $b_0 \in \mathfrak{M}_j$. With the hypothesis, $ev_i(D_{j+1}) = \emptyset \implies ev_i(b_0) = \emptyset$, hence $b_0 \in \mathfrak{M}_{j+1}$.

For (2): let D and $\mathfrak{M}_*$ be the final display and entanglement, so $\mathfrak{M}_* = \rho(\Delta(s, \mathfrak{M}))$. If $ev_i(D) = \emptyset$ then $ev_i(b) = \emptyset$ for every $b \in \mathfrak{M}_*$, by the re-cut; so $ev_i(\mathfrak{M}_*) = \emptyset$. Conversely, a stone of D at an intersection i with $ev_i(\mathfrak{M}_*) = \emptyset$ would be removed by a further round, and the repetition has stabilized. $\square$

Let *Go* be the classical game with Chinese style area scoring and standard pass move, with the following stipulations: suicide is a legal move, as for example in the Tromp–Taylor rules [31, 30], there is no Ko or superko rule, and the game ends by a double pass: a state of *Go* is final exactly after two consecutive passes, Definition 4.7. The same convention is fixed for *SGo* and its variants below: a state is final exactly after a double pass turn. Of the end of the game rules of Section 2.6 this keeps the double pass alone, ending by agreement not being an automaton notion, Remark 4.4. The board is any square board of side at least two.⁷

In the terms of Definition 4.7: the core states of *Go* are the classical diagrams, the initial core state the empty diagram, no core state is ended by play, and the non pass moves act as resolved below. A non pass move plays to an empty intersection; a pass changes nothing. For a classical diagram B and a non pass move m whose placement intersection is empty in B , write $B + m$ for B with the stone of m entered at its placement intersection – the *placed diagram*. Components and liberties are read off a diagram. For a legal classical state b with $b \# m$ defined, write $B = \text{diagram}(b)$; classical play resolves:

- (1) The components captured by the move are the opposite colored components of $B + m$ with no liberties in it.
- (2) The component of the placed stone suicides if and only if it has no liberties in $B + m$ with the captured components emptied.
- (3) The diagram of $b \# m$ is $B + m$ with the captured and suicided components emptied; in particular the move fills no intersection but its placement intersection.

We write $B \# m$ for this diagram: $\text{diagram}(b \# m) = \text{diagram}(b) \# m$.

Theorem 5.2. *On a board of side at least five: *SGo*, the delayed games k -*DSGo* for $k \geq 1$, and *DSGo* are simple simultaneizations of *Go*. Their faithfulness radii are, respectively, zero, exactly k , and infinity. In particular the radius spectrum of *Go* is all of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$.*

⁷The 1×1 board is a genuine exception: there the joint move to the sole intersection commutes – each lone stone is a suicide – while the display keeps a q-stone, and faithfulness fails at distance zero. Theorem 5.2 is stated for side at least five: the witness for the radius of k -*DSGo* pads with turns in a corner away from its stones. The clauses on *SGo* and *DSGo* hold from side two on, the *SGo* witness using side at least three, and the 2×2 board computer exhaustion, which finds failures at distance one for *SGo* and at distance two for 1-*DSGo*.

Proof. Call the games in the hypothesis the *SGo family*. Conditions 1 and 2, for the family, are by construction and a direct analogue of Lemma 4.3.

Let $\rho : B(SGo) \rightarrow B(\text{Sim}(Go))$ send a state to its entanglement component: the entanglement state is a finite set of states of *Go* in position normal form – the terms of P are normalized – that is an element of $B(\text{Sim}(Go))$. Then $\rho(q_0) = \{q_0\} = q'_0$. For *DSGo* and the delayed games, ρ likewise reads the entanglement component $\mathfrak{M}$. The branch evolution of Section 4.1 is precisely the evolution by the serialization map P : playing the two moves in both orders, with a move to an occupied intersection forfeited, is the prescription defining P . So $E_{SGo}(s, m_0, m_1)$ is obtained by applying the *OR* prunings to $E_{\text{Sim}(Go)}(\rho(s), m_0, m_1)$, and the inclusion in condition 3 holds by construction, similarly for the other members of the family.

For the definedness direction of condition 3: a move of *SGo* is available if and only if its placement intersection is empty on the display; a branch kept by the reduction has all its stones within the display, a branch occupying a display-empty intersection being incompatible with the display and discarded; so a display-empty intersection is empty in every branch, and the joint move is available in $\text{Sim}(Go)$ at $\rho(s)$. This is similar, for the rest of the family.

We verify condition 4 following the recursion of Definition 4.16. At the initial state it is the normalization $\rho(q_0) = q'_0$. For the step: suppose s is semi-classical with associated state a and $\rho(s) = \{a\}$, and let s' be the state after a turn m_0/m_1 commuting at a , with a' its associated state (Definition 4.16). It is enough to verify that $\rho(s') = \{a'\}$, ρ the branch semantics of the respective game.

For $\text{Sim}(Go)$ this is immediate: ρ is the identity, and at a commuting turn the two composites have the common position normal form a' :

$$E_{\text{Sim}(Go)}(\{a\}, m_0, m_1) = P(a, m_0, m_1) = \{a'\}.$$

For *DSGo*, we have observed in Section 5.1 that $\rho \circ E_{DSGo} = E_{\text{Sim}(Go)} \circ \rho$, hence it follows by the above.

For *DSGo* we also have

$$\text{diagram}(s) = \text{diagram}(a) \implies \text{diagram}(s') = \text{diagram}(a').$$

The equality we need to show is: $ev_i(s') = ev_i(a')$ at every intersection i . On the empty intersections this is Lemma 5.1(2), applied to $\rho(s') = \{a'\}$. Concretely, the first postprocessing round empties the intersections of the placed display that are empty in a' – the stones the turn removes in classical play – and the second round changes nothing. We show that on the occupied intersections the colors are those of a' . A non q-stone of the turn is placed as in a' . A q-stone of the turn is recolored by the postprocessing rounds, read off $\{a'\}$. An older stone has its color by the hypothesis, a' keeping the stones of a it does not remove.

For *k-DSGo* the recursion carries two more invariants: $\text{diagram}(s) = \text{diagram}(a)$, and the stored verdicts of s are empty. At the initial state all three hold. For the step: the executed verdict is empty, so the display is unchanged, and the turn is a turn of *DSGo*; $\rho(s') = \{a'\}$ and $\text{diagram}(s') = \text{diagram}(a')$ as above. The new verdict is empty. The equality $\text{diagram}(s') = \text{diagram}(a')$ reads: $ev_i(s') = ev_i(a')$ at every intersection i . No $ev_i(a')$ is the pair, so no q-stone stands on the display of s' . Components and liberties are read off the diagram, and a' is legal: every component of the display has a liberty, no component is trapped, and *OR* removes and recolors nothing.

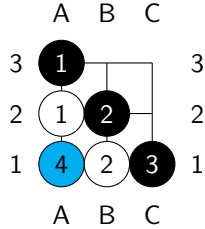
For *SGo* the recursion carries the invariant $\text{diagram}(s) = \text{diagram}(a)$. It propagates by Lemma 5.3 below: $\text{diagram}(s') = \text{diagram}(a')$. The branches of the turn are $P(\{a\}, m_0, m_1) = \{a'\}$. The equality $\text{diagram}(s') = \text{diagram}(a')$ reads: $ev_i(s') = ev_i(a')$ at every intersection i . So every stone of a' occupies an intersection occupied on the display of s' , with its color: a' is compatible, and survives the pruning: $\rho(s') = \{a'\}$.

To verify the simplicity property: since in our version of *Go* suicide is a legal move and there is no Ko rule, for any non final state a of *Go* the interface $\mathbb{I}(a)$ consists of the pass moves and the moves of either player to the empty intersections of a . Likewise, for a non final $s \in B(\text{SGo})$, $I(s)$ consists of the pass moves and the moves of either player to the empty intersections of s . So it suffices to exhibit a legally obtainable state $\phi(s)$ of *Go* with the same empty intersections as s . Let $\phi(s)$ be obtained by replacing every stone of s by a black stone. It is easy to see that $\phi(s)$ is legally obtainable.

The simplicity argument applies verbatim to the rest of the family. For these games, the inclusion of condition 3 is the re-cut of Δ , by definition; and a surviving element occupies only display-occupied intersections, which gives the definedness direction as before.

It remains to compute the radii of the family.

For *SGo*: at a semi-classical state s with associated state a , $\text{diagram}(s) = \text{diagram}(a)$ and $\rho(s) = \{a\}$, as established above; so $I(s) = \mathbb{I}(a)$. The finality clause holds by the convention fixed above: a semi-classical state is final exactly after a double pass turn, and so is its associated state. Thus *SGo* is faithful within distance zero. It is not faithful within distance one: reach, by commuting turns, black stones on A3, B2, C1 and white stones on A2, B1, and play the conflict A1/A1, reaching a state s' :



In one order Black's A1 captures A2 and B1; in the other White's A1 is a suicide, and Black's A1 then lands on the emptied intersection. Both orders produce the same state, with A2 and B1 empty; the entanglement of s' is its singleton. On the display, the created q-stone is trapped by White on this turn, so Condition 3a fails for each white stone; and Condition 3b fails on its component clause, the q-stone's component carrying no stone of the turn that is not a q-stone. So the *OR* removes nothing (compare the last example of Section 3.1). So A2 and B1 stand on the display yet are empty in every element of the entanglement: $I(s') \subsetneq \bigcap_{b \in \rho(s')} \mathbb{I}(b)$. The radius of *SGo* is zero.

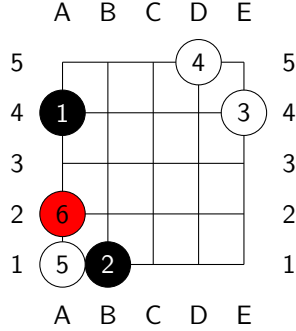
For the radius of *DSGo*: by the convention fixed above a state s' is final exactly after a double pass turn, and then every element of $\rho(s')$ is final, $P(b, 0, 0) = \{b \# 0 \# 0\}$ for every branch b : the finality clause holds wherever $\rho(s')$ is nonempty.

For the move clause, at any reachable state s and any turn, with s' the resulting state: $\rho(s')$ is the entire decoherence $P(\rho(s), m_0, m_1)$, as observed in Section 5.1,

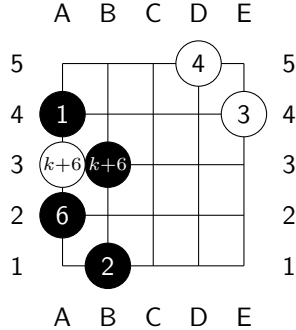
and it is nonempty. By Lemma 5.1(2), an intersection is empty on the display of s' if and only if it is empty in every element of $\rho(s')$, that is $I(s') = \bigcap_{b \in \rho(s')} \mathbb{I}(b)$: faithfulness at s' . So *DSGo* is faithful at every state reachable in play, and its faithfulness radius is infinite.

For the radius of k -*DSGo*: within distance k of classical play, every verdict that executes is one of the k verdicts stored at the semi-classical state, the j -th turn after it executing the j -th oldest; all are empty, as shown above. So every turn within this distance is a turn of *DSGo*, and the preceding argument applies: k -*DSGo* is faithful within distance k .

It is not faithful within distance $k + 1$. Reach, by commuting turns, black stones on A4 and B1 and white stones on A1 and on the two neighbors of the corner opposite A1 – E4 and D5 on the 5×5 board – and play the conflict A2/A2:



The conflict resolves by the lowest priority case of the serialization map P : the entanglement becomes $\{a_0, a_1\}$, where in a_0 Black's A2 has captured A1, and in a_1 White's A2 has joined A1. The verdict of the new display – A1 removed, the q-stone made definite as black – is stored. Then, for $k - 1$ turns, Black plays the corner opposite A1 and White passes. In every branch the move is a single stone suicide, the neighbors of the corner being white, and the branch is unchanged. On the display the placed stone stands in no branch: the first round of Δ removes it, and display and entanglement return to those after the conflict. Each of these turns executes an empty verdict, stored before the conflict. Now play B3/A3, reaching a state s' at distance $k + 1$ of classical play:



In E_k : the executed verdict is that of the conflict; its execution has emptied A1 and recolored the q-stone black, its stamp kept; the placement has added B3 and A3. In $P(a_0, B3, A3)$ the white A3 has no liberty – A2, A4 and B3 are black – and is gone, a suicide in one order and a capture in the other; write a'_0 for the single

outcome. In $P(a_1, B3, A3)$ the white A3 joins A1 and A2, and the component keeps the liberty B2. Every element of $P(a_1, B3, A3)$ occupies A1, empty on the display, and the re-cut of Δ removes them: $\rho(s') = \{a'_0\}$. A3 is empty in a'_0 yet stands on the display. The verdict execution changes only the display. The elements of $P(a_1, B3, A3)$ therefore still stand at the removal round of Δ : they occupy A3 and protect it. They are discarded only at the re-cut, and the recursion stops with the display unchanged. So $I(s') \subsetneq \bigcap_{b \in \rho(s')} \mathbb{I}(b)$, and the radius of k -DSGo is exactly k .

The mechanism, for contrast with DSGo: there every stone of the display stands in some branch, the postprocessing keeping the whole decoherence. In k -DSGo the executed verdict empties an intersection of the display alone. The branches still occupying it fail the re-cut; a display stone occupied in those branches alone then stands in no branch.

The proof is now complete. The theorem and the following supporting lemma are formally verified: a machine checked proof in Lean 4 (core library only), the theorem at every board side at least five, the lemma at every side at least two and every turn, the pass cases included. The checked statement follows the proof: the semi-classical recursion, the naturality and simplicity conditions, the finality convention, and the radii as faithfulness within d and its failure within $d+1$. Lemmas 4.14 and 4.21 are verified as well. The formal notions carry no scoring partition: the win and draw clauses of Definitions 4.2 and 4.9 are carried as the preservation of finality, and the scoring clause of Lemma 4.21 holds by construction. The development is at <https://yashamon.github.io/web2/papers/sgoleanformalization/>, release 1.1. Its README gives the four command verification and the axiom certificate. $\square$

Lemma 5.3 (One-stage resolution of commuting turns). *Let s be a semi-classical state of SGo with associated state a , and $\text{diagram}(s) = \text{diagram}(a)$. Let m_0/m_1 be a joint move commuting at a , and let a' be the associated state of $s' = E_{SGo}(s, m_0, m_1)$, per Definition 4.16. Then the resolution of the turn consists of capture reductions at the current turn alone, and $\text{diagram}(s') = \text{diagram}(a')$.*

The proof is elementary but has many moving parts. One can say that the E_{SGo} evolution is fine tuned for the lemma. The reader may recall the example of Section 3.3, which exemplifies the lemma firing – and shows how close the lemma is to failing: without the component clause it simply fails.

Proof. The state a is legal, being reached by classical play. Write A for $\text{diagram}(a)$, n for the current turn, D for the display of s , and D^+ for the display with the turn's stones placed: the stamps of D are below n , the placed stones stamped n . Components, liberties and adjacency refer to D^+ unless a state or a diagram is named.

Step 0 (a commuting joint move places on distinct empty intersections, or passes). In other words, for non pass moves m_0, m_1 to the same intersection i , $a \# m_0 \# m_1$ and $a \# m_1 \# m_0$ cannot both be defined.

Say $a \# m_0 \# m_1$ is defined. Then i is empty in $a \# m_0$: Black's stone is emptied at its own move. A component captured by m_0 is white, trapped in $A + m_0$, and adjacent to i : elsewhere the fill changes no liberties, and a is legal. Its emptied intersections would be liberties of Black's component at the suicide condition (2): Black's stone would stand. So m_0 captures nothing. So Black's component is trapped in $A + m_0$ itself: every black neighbor of i lies in a component of A whose

one liberty is i , and no white component of A has i as its one liberty: such a component would be captured. Now play m_1 first. White's placement at i captures those black components (1). The component of White's stone keeps a liberty: an empty neighbor of i , an intersection just freed, or a liberty of a white neighbor other than i . The white stone stands. So i is occupied in $a\#m_1$, and $a\#m_1\#m_0$ is undefined.

In particular, D^+ carries no q-stone, and condition 2 and the q-clauses are vacuous. Call a stone of the turn, and the intersection it occupies, *fresh*; a component of D^+ is *fresh* if it contains a fresh stone, and *old* otherwise. Since a is legal and $\text{diagram}(D) = \text{diagram}(a)$, no component of D is trapped. A component trapped in D^+ therefore contains or neighbors a fresh stone: the turn fills only the fresh intersections. Such a component is trapped on turn n .

The operator reads s from its display, so the hypothesis reads $\text{diagram}(D) = A$. Write A^+ for $\text{diagram}(D^+)$: it is A with the fresh intersections filled in their colors. Components, liberties and trapping of D^+ and of A^+ agree. Write A' for $A\#m_0\#m_1$. The composites $a\#m_0\#m_1$ and $a\#m_1\#m_0$ have the common position normal form a' , and diagram forgets the gradings: $A' = \text{diagram}(a') = A\#m_1\#m_0$.

The placement intersection of m_1 is empty in $A - a\#m_1$ is defined, the turn commuting – and differs from that of m_0 , by Step 0; symmetrically for m_0 . The move m_1 fills only its placement intersection (3). So an intersection empty in $A\#m_0$ and occupied in A is not the placement intersection of m_1 , and is empty in $A\#m_0\#m_1$; and so is the placement intersection of m_0 , when empty in $A\#m_0$. In particular an intersection of $A + m_0$ empty in $A\#m_0$ is empty in A' : it is occupied in A , or is the placement intersection of m_0 . So A' is A^+ with a set of intersections emptied: its stones are stones of A^+ , and no stone recolors.

Step 1 (removal dichotomy). Every component C of A^+ stands entire in A' – its intersections keep their values – or is entirely empty in A' ; an empty one is trapped in A^+ .

For the dichotomy: suppose C stands partial. Being connected, C contains adjacent stones z and w , z occupied and w empty in A' .



Left, the joint move A3/C3. The white pair is one component of $A + m_0$, and is captured whole: adjacent stones share their fate. Right, the joint move B1/A3. The sole liberty of A2 is the placement intersection of m_1 , empty in $A + m_0$: A2 survives m_0 , and stands with the stone of m_1 in A' .

The stone w is a stone of $A + m_0$ empty in $A\#m_0$, or a stone of $(A\#m_0) + m_1$ empty in $A\#m_0\#m_1$; set $Q = A + m_0$ in the first case, $Q = (A\#m_0) + m_1$ in the second. By (1)–(3), w lies in a captured or suicided component R of Q . The component R has no liberties in Q : the suicided component has none even with the captures emptied. The stone z is occupied in A' . The intersections of the captured and suicided components of either move are empty in A' . So z lies in no

such component. If z is a stone of Q , it lies in R , adjacent to w and of its color: a contradiction. Otherwise $Q = A + m_0$ and z is the stone of m_1 : its intersection – empty in A , not the placement intersection of m_0 – is empty in Q , adjacent to R : a liberty, a contradiction.

For the trapping: $A + m_0$ and $(A \# m_0) + m_1$ carry at most the stones of A^+ , so a component removed from either has no liberties in A^+ . The stones of an entirely empty component lie in such removed components, and every intersection adjacent to it is adjacent to one of these: it is trapped in A^+ .

Call a component of A^+ *dead* if it is empty in A' , and *live* otherwise.

Step 2 (untrapped components are live). By Step 1 a dead component is trapped in A^+ ; contrapositively, an untrapped component is live.

Step 3 (old trapped components are dead). Let T be old and trapped, white say. The stones of T are stones of A , and T is trapped in A^+ : every liberty of T in A is a fresh intersection. The placement intersection of m_1 is no liberty of T : the white stone there would lie in T 's component, and T is a component of A^+ . The state a is legal: T has a liberty in A . So T has exactly one liberty in A : the placement intersection of the black move m_0 . In $A + m_0$ that liberty is filled: T is an opposite colored component of it with no liberties, and is captured (1). So the intersections of T are empty in $A \# m_0$, hence in A' : T is dead. A black T is captured by m_1 along $A \# m_1 \# m_0$, which is A' as well.

Step 4 (live trapped components are fresh, with a dead donor). Let B be trapped and live. In A' the stones of B stand. A stone of A' is a stone of A^+ , and a stone of A^+ adjacent to B is not of B 's color, B being a component of A^+ : the stones of B are a component of A' . The state a' is legal, so this component has a liberty in A' . That intersection is occupied in A^+ : B is trapped there. Its component in A^+ is dead, by Step 1. Call it a *donor* of B . A donor is adjacent to B , and opposite colored. By Step 3, B is fresh.

The component clause example of Section 3.3 shows the situation: the black group through B3 is trapped and live, and the captured pair is its donor.

Step 5 (no two dead components are adjacent). Suppose dead T and dead Z are adjacent; they are opposite colored, a same colored pair being one component. As for w in Step 1, each stone of a dead component is a stone of $A + m_0$ empty in $A \# m_0$, or a stone of $(A \# m_0) + m_1$ empty in $A \# m_0 \# m_1$.

Definition 5.4. We say in the case above that the stone **dies at** m_0 , respectively at m_1 .

Fix adjacent stones x of T and y of Z . First suppose x dies at m_0 and y at m_1 , or vice versa; say the former. Write i for the intersection of x . The intersection i is not the placement intersection j of m_1 : it is occupied in $A + m_0$, and j is not. So i is empty in $(A \# m_0) + m_1$, and the component of y in the latter has i as a liberty. But y dies at m_1 : its component is captured or suicided, with no liberties there, as in Step 1. A contradiction. So x and y die at one move; write m for it.

One of x and y has the color of m , the other the opposite; say y does. The stone y is emptied, and its component at m is not captured: captured components are opposite colored (1). So that component is suicided: it is the component of the placed stone (2). And x , opposite colored, is captured: an emptied stone lies in a captured or suicided component (3), and the suicided one has the color of m . The suicide condition (2) reads the placed diagram with the captures emptied. There

the placed stone's component is adjacent to the emptied intersection of x , a liberty, and does not suicide: a contradiction.

Step 6 (the reduction removes only dead components). Write D_k for $\widetilde{Cap}_n^k(D^+)$. We show by induction on k : every stone of D^+ empty in D_k lies in a dead component, and every dead component is empty in D_k entire, or stands in D_k entire. For $k = 0$ there is nothing to show. Suppose the claim holds at k . By Step 5, removals of dead components never free a dead component: every dead component standing in D_k is trapped in D_k . It also stays trapped on turn n . A dead fresh component contains a stone of the turn. A dead old component is adjacent, by Step 3, to the opposite colored stone of the turn at its one liberty of A . That stone's component is live by Step 5, and stands in D_k , by the claim at k . Now let $\widetilde{Cap}_n$ capture C in D_k , and suppose a stone of C were live: its component B of A^+ stands in D_k , by the claim at k , and $C = B$: B is connected in D_k , and C in A^+ . Trapped in D_k , B is trapped in A^+ , whose empty intersections are empty in D_k . By Step 4, B is fresh, with a dead donor T adjacent. B fresh blocks condition **3b**: a stone of B is of the turn. If T is empty in D_k , its intersections are liberties of C : not trapped. If T stands in D_k , entire by the claim at k , it is still trapped on turn n , and condition **3a** fails for C . Either way C is not captured: a contradiction. So every stone of C is dead. The dead component of one of them stands entire in D_k ; it is connected in D_k , so it lies in C ; and C , connected in A^+ , lies in it: C is that component. The removals stay entire, and the claim holds at $k + 1$.

Step 7 (progress, and at most two removing applications). Consider the first application, D_0 to D_1 . Let T be a dead old component, white say. Its adjacent opposite colored stones trapped in D_0 lie in live components: dead neighbors do not exist, by Step 5. Live trapped components are fresh, by Step 4. So condition **3b** holds for T : no stone of T is of the turn, and every adjacent trapped component contains a stone of the turn that is not a q-stone. Every dead old component is captured on the first application.

Now let T be a dead fresh component, through m_1 say. Its possible blocker for condition **3a** is an adjacent trapped opposite colored component; by Step 5 it is live, by Step 4 fresh: the component Z of the stone of m_0 . Suppose Z is adjacent to T and trapped in D_0 . Some dead old white component is adjacent to Z . Suppose not, and work along $A \# m_0 \# m_1$. A white captured by m_0 is dead and old, its stones being stones of A . It is not of T : an old white part of T is a component of A , and T is connected: the part is adjacent to the stone of m_1 , and its placement intersection, empty in $A + m_0$, is a liberty of the part. So none is adjacent to Z . Then either Z has no liberties at the suicide condition of m_0 **(2)** and suicides, or its one liberty is the placement intersection of m_1 , filled by m_1 , whose captures then remove Z **(1)**. In both cases Z is empty in A' , hence dead: a contradiction. The adjacent dead old white component is captured on the first application, freeing Z : in D_1 the component Z is no longer trapped, condition **3a** holds for T , and T is captured.

So every dead component is empty in D_2 : at most two applications remove stones, and $Cap_n(D^+)$ empties exactly the dead components.

Step 8 (later stages are quiet, and conclusion). The removals at turn n only emptied intersections. The stones standing are the live components: by Steps 1–4, exactly the stones of A' . The state a' is legal: no component of A' is trapped. So Cap_t removes nothing for $t < n$, and the recursion stops.

8	.	n	b	q	k	b	n	r
7	.	p	p	p	p	p	p	p
6	.	r	.	.	.	.	.	.
5	p	.	.	.	.	.	.	.
4	P	.	.	.	.	.	.	.
3	.	R	.	.	.	.	.	.
2	.	P	P	P	P	P	P	P
1	.	N	B	Q	K	B	N	R
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h

FIGURE 1. The state a^* , reached by the mirror pairs $a4/a5$; $Ra3/Ra6$; $Rb3/Rb6$. White pieces are in capitals. The conflicting simultaneous moves are the rook moves $m_0 : b3 \rightarrow b5$ and $m_1 = \mathcal{A}(m_0) : b6 \rightarrow b4$.

No recoloring occurred, there being no q-stone. So

$$\text{diagram}(OR(D^+)) = \text{diagram}(a').$$

And $OR(D^+)$ is the display of s' : $\text{diagram}(s') = \text{diagram}(a')$. If a move is a pass, the same argument runs with one fresh intersection. $\square$

Remark 5.5. *Step 7 shows the repetition needs at most two removing applications on any board: there are at most two fresh components, and the second application serves only a dead fresh component shielded by the other. This is consistent with the recursion depth statistic of Section 2.1.*

5.2. Chess and faithfulness. We now come to the main reason for studying faithfulness: it gives rise to a qualitative mathematical difference between chess and *Go*.

Theorem 5.6. *$\widetilde{\text{chess}}$ has no simple simultaneization that is faithful within distance one of classical play: equivalently, none of positive faithfulness radius. In particular, the universal simultaneization $\text{Sim}(\text{chess})$ is not simple.*

Proof. First a technical lemma.

Lemma 5.7. *Let G_1 be a simultaneization of G_0 , and suppose that $s \in B(G_1)$ is obtained from the initial state by a game history consisting of mirror pairs, that is, of simultaneous pairs of the form $(x_i, \mathcal{A}(x_i))$. Then $\mathcal{R}(s) = s$, and consequently $\mathcal{A}(I(s)) = I(s)$.*

Proof. The mirror of the pair $(x, \mathcal{A}(x))$ is the pair $(\mathcal{A}(\mathcal{A}(x)), \mathcal{A}(x)) = (x, \mathcal{A}(x))$ itself. So applying the symmetry property of Definition 4.2, and the order invariance of E (the last property of Definition 4.1), along the game history, together with $\mathcal{R}(q_0) = q_0$, we get $\mathcal{R}(s) = s$. Then for any m , $E_{G_1}(s, m)$ is defined if and only if $E_{G_1}(\mathcal{R}(s), \mathcal{A}(m)) = E_{G_1}(s, \mathcal{A}(m))$ is defined, giving $\mathcal{A}(I(s)) = I(s)$. $\square$

Now return to the proof of the theorem. Let G_1 be any simultaneization of $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$ faithful within distance one of classical play, with P_0 the White player, and consider the game history of G_1 consisting of the mirror pairs

$$a4/a5; \quad Ra3/Ra6; \quad Rb3/Rb6,$$

in standard chess algebraic notation. The moves of each pair do not interact, so both orders of play are pseudo legal with the same outcome, and each state along this history is semi-classical. By the semi-classicality condition of Definition 4.17 together with faithfulness at the semi-classical states, applied inductively along the history, the history is legal in G_1 and for the resulting state $s^* \in B(G_1)$ we have $\rho(s^*) = \{a^*\}$, with a^* the classical state of Figure 1. Note that this pins down $\rho(s^*)$ for every simultaneization G_1 , whatever its branch semantics.

Now let m_0 be the White rook move $b3 \rightarrow b5$, and $m_1 = \mathcal{A}(m_0)$ the Black rook move $b6 \rightarrow b4$. Each order of these moves blocks the other: after $b3 \rightarrow b5$ the Black rook's path is blocked at $b5$, while after $b6 \rightarrow b4$ the White rook's path is blocked at $b4$. So in $\text{Sim}(\widetilde{\text{chess}})$ this pair resolves by the lowest priority case of the serialization map P , and

$$P(a^*, m_0, m_1) = \{a_0, a_1\},$$

where in a_0 the White rook stands on $b5$ with the Black rook on $b6$, and a_1 is the mirror image of a_0 . By faithfulness at the semi-classical s^* , the pair (m_0, m_1) , being available in $\text{Sim}(\widetilde{\text{chess}})$ at $\{a^*\}$, is available at s^* ; so $s_1^* = E_{G_1}(s^*, m_0, m_1)$ is defined, and by condition 3 together with faithfulness at s_1^* – a state one turn from s^* – $\rho(s_1^*)$ is a nonempty subset of $\{a_0, a_1\}$. Moreover s_1^* is not final: it is within distance one of the semi-classical s^* , so the finality clause of faithfulness applies, and neither a_0 nor a_1 is final in $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$.

Suppose that $\rho(s_1^*)$ is a singleton, say $\{a_0\}$. The history of s_1^* consists of mirror pairs, so by Lemma 5.7 $I(s_1^*)$ is $\mathcal{A}$ invariant. But by faithfulness at s_1^* , $I(s_1^*) = \mathbb{I}(a_0)$, which is not $\mathcal{A}$ invariant: in a_0 White has rook moves from $b5$, while Black has no rook moves from $b4$. The case of $\{a_1\}$ is mirrored. Thus a singleton value is forbidden by the symmetry of G_1 , and $\rho(s_1^*) = \{a_0, a_1\}$.

By faithfulness at s_1^* , $I(s_1^*) = \mathbb{I}(a_0) \cap \mathbb{I}(a_1)$, which is computed directly: for each player it consists of the pass move, the moves of the c through h pawns, and the four knight moves. There are no queen side rook moves, as these rooks stand on different squares in a_0 and a_1 , and no a or b pawn moves. Now suppose that G_1 is simple, so that there is a legally obtainable state c of $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$ with $\mathbb{I}(c)$ equal to this set. The interface $\mathbb{I}(c)$ forces every piece of c other than the two queen side rooks, the two a pawns and the two b pawns to stand on its starting square. One now checks the finitely many placements, or absences by capture, of the six remaining pieces, and each fails. For example, if the White b pawn is at $b2$, then $b3$ must be occupied, necessarily by a queen side rook or the Black b pawn, giving respectively a legal rook move from $b3$ and the legal capture $b3 \times c2$, neither of which is in the set; while if the White b pawn is absent, having been captured, and $b2$ is unoccupied, then the $c1$ bishop has the legal move to $b2$, again not in the set. So we have a contradiction, and G_1 is not simple. $\square$

5.3. Mirror-tie chess. The faithfulness hypothesis in Theorem 5.6 cannot be dropped. Define the *mirror-tie game* G_1 : play proceeds as in $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$ but with simultaneously declared moves, as long as the two moves of each turn do not genuinely interact – both orders of play legal and with the same outcome. Thus each state s so reached is semi-classical, with $\rho(s)$ the singleton of its classical state. At the first genuinely conflicting move pair the game locks: only the pass moves remain available. After two consecutive passes the game ends in a tie.

The conditions of Definition 4.17 are readily verified; the locked states, having only passes available, are exempt from the simplicity condition, and at every other state the interface is that of a classical state. So G_1 is a simple simultaneization of $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$, of faithfulness radius zero. (Fully degenerate examples also exist: the game in which only passes are ever available is a simple simultaneization of any G_0 with a pass move, vacuously.) Together with Theorem 5.6: the radius spectrum of $\widetilde{\text{chess}}$ is $\{0\}$ – its conflicts can be refused, but not played out – while the radius spectrum of Go is all of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$, by Theorem 5.2. Nothing in the mirror-tie construction is special to chess, so every game of our standing kind has zero in its radius spectrum. Within the hierarchy of Go : SGo continues past every conflict at radius zero, embracing the divergences; each turn of delay buys one level; DSGo , all delay, is faithful everywhere. The pattern of the objective reduction – prune the state, against the branch evolution, by the game’s own rules – is not special to Go ; we develop it only here.

Question 5.8. *Which subsets of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$ arise as radius spectra? Chess and Go realize $\{0\}$ and the whole of $\mathbb{N} \sqcup \{\infty\}$. We do not know whether a spectrum must be an initial segment. Nor do we know a game of finite positive absolute radius – a spectrum with finite positive supremum – but it is hard to imagine an obstruction.*

How does the radius spectrum sit among known invariants of games? The classical invariants are functionals of the scoring. The Conway value, the temperature, the outcome class: each is computed from the terminal values, by backward induction [4, 2]. The same holds for the invariants obtained by perturbing the turn mechanism. Under auction play, the Richman value is a threshold for winning [16, 5]. Under random turn order, the value is a winning probability [22]. The complexity class of a game family is the cost of deciding the winner; notably it does not draw our line, as generalized chess and Go with a simple Ko rule are both EXPTIME complete [8, 26]. The radius spectrum is of the same species – an invariant born of perturbing the turn mechanism – but it alone is blind to the scoring. It is a function of the dynamics alone (Lemma 4.21): replacing the scoring of Go by any other function of final displays changes nothing in Theorem 5.2. Purely dynamical equivalences of automata are the subject of concurrency theory: bisimulation, and the trace theory of commuting actions [18, 17]. A commuting turn is a diamond in that language, and $\text{Sim}(G_0)$ resembles the passage from interleaving semantics to true concurrency. We do not know a numerical invariant of that theory in the role of the radius.

6. INFORMED PLAY AND CONCLUDING REMARKS

The focus of this section is our informed play experiments: their methodology and partial results, for both games. All figures below are for the 5×5 board, and may be compared directly with the random play columns of the table of Section 2.1. The restriction to 5×5 is due to computational cost: for SGo , estimating the equilibrium with our very blunt methods is expensive even on 5×5 .

6.1. Equilibrium guided play. Our equilibrium guided play is computed as follows: at each turn both players are offered a random menu of five moves; the resulting 5×5 matrix of joint outcomes is filled by averaging the final margins of

short uniformly random continuations;⁸ and each player samples their move from an optimal mixed strategy of this zero sum matrix game. Three technical findings. First, at about 74% of the turns the estimated one turn game has *no pure saddle point*, so the players must randomize – consistent with Section 4.2, where mixing is proved necessary already on the 3×3 board (re-estimating the matrices at fivefold rollout depth, on fixed states and menus, lowers the mixing fraction from 74% to 54% on a control sample; genuine mixing remains). Second, the within turn value spread is large, about 16 points of the twenty-five: the joint move choice of a single turn swings most of the board. Third, the summary table of the next subsection shows that equilibrium guided play leaves the creation of entanglement essentially unchanged relative to the random play columns of the table of Section 2.1 (3.2 q-stones created per game against 3.3): the entanglement is a stable feature of the game, of order one under random and informed play alike.

6.2. Versus informed play in classical Go. For the classical game we use greedy rollout guided play: at each move the player evaluates up to six candidate moves, and the pass, by twelve random rollouts each (the convention of the preceding footnote), and plays the best. The summary of informed self play, for both games, in the format of the table of Section 2.1 (162 and 165 games; unbounded play in both cases; these runs predate the depth statistic and report branch counts instead):

	<i>SGo</i>	classical <i>Go</i>
mean margin	11.7	11.4
draws	5.6%	6.7%
games ending on their own	100%	100%
mean length in turns	21.2	17.8
q-stones created per game	3.2	–
q-stones on the final display	2.3	–
peak number of branches	4.2	–
final number of branches	3.2	–

For *SGo* the table is close to its random play columns: the margin eases (11.7 against 13.6), the draw rate and game length barely move, and the entanglement is unchanged in creation and slightly more resolved by the end. For the classical game the change is termination: informed play supplies the endings that random play never reaches – every game now ends on its own, in 17.8 turns on average – while *SGo* terminates by rule either way.

At this shallow search depth no measurable first mover advantage emerges in *Go* (signed mean margins statistically zero). Hence we are not correcting by any Komi, which is also why draws appear for *Go* in the table above. We note that *Go* is solved on the 5×5 board – a win for Black by 25 points under standard rule formalizations [32] – a reminder that these are partial, shallow search depth results.

Whether the above observations persist for equilibrium guided play on large boards, along with the sharpness observed in Section 2.1, we leave to future study.

6.3. An Elo ladder. Sharp dynamics alone do not distinguish a deep game from a coin flip. A standard proxy for depth is the length of the improvement ladder: how much playing strength a fixed family of agents can climb before it saturates [15];

⁸Rollouts use the standard Monte Carlo playout convention: uniformly random moves, except that a player does not fill their own single point eyes and does not play suicide, passing when no other move is available.

strength against computational budget is likewise standard in the study of game-playing programs [14]. We ran one ladder for both games, on the 5×5 board, with the same architecture: Monte Carlo agents indexed by a rollout budget, choosing from a random menu of five moves by random playouts, the opponent modeled as random. Adjacent budgets played 100 games each, colors alternating; the final pair played 60. The Elo gap of a pair is $400 \log_{10}(s/(1-s))$, with s the stronger agent’s mean score.

budgets	<i>SGo</i>	<i>Go</i>
0 v. 16	+308	+173
16 v. 128	+330	+89
128 v. 1024	+215	+63
1024 v. 2048	+52	−45
2048 v. 4096	0	−
ladder	≈ 900	≈ 300

Both ladders saturate. That of *Go* does so by budget 1024: its last rung is negative, within noise of zero. Direct matches between non adjacent rungs agree with the summed gaps, in both games: the ladders hide no cycles. A control with komi one half, which eliminates draws, leaves the ladder of *Go* essentially unchanged: the disparity is not an artifact of the draw channel.

These figures must be properly interpreted. They are relative to this agent family, and they lower bound the depth rather than measure it. Still, on the same board and by the same yardstick, the ladder of *SGo* is three times the height, and the scale is exponential in nature.

6.4. Lazy evaluation. Finally, we note that the pattern of resolution in *SGo* – branchings accumulate silently until objective information forces their evaluation – is also familiar in computer science, notably in lazy evaluation [10, 13], where a deferred computation is forced exactly when its value is demanded.

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